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Power shift in Karnataka as Siddaramaiah resigns

Two-time Chief Minister points at his deputy Shivakumar as successor after stepping down from the post; not interested in national politics, will fight communal forces till last breath, he declares

Sharath S. Srivatsa
BENGALURU

Two-time Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah tendered his resignation on Thursday, paving the way for transition of power to his deputy D.K. Shivakumar. The formation of the next government is likely to be discussed in Delhi on Friday.

After visiting the Lok Bhavan to hand over his resignation to the Special Secretary to Governor Thaa-warchand Gehlot, who was away in Indore, Mr. Siddaramaiah proceeded to Delhi for talks with the Congress central leadership over the formation of the next government.

However, his flight was diverted to Jaipur owing to bad weather on Thursday



Rein change: Siddaramaiah leaves after a press meet in Bengaluru on Thursday. D.K. Shivakumar is also seen. SUDHAKARA JAIN

night. Mr. Shivakumar also left for Delhi.

Though the Congress is yet to formally name his successor, Mr. Siddaramaiah, during a media conference, pointed to Mr. Shivakumar as the next Chief Minister. There has also been no official word on the Congress Legisla-

ture Party meeting, although speculation is rife that it could take place on Friday evening.

"I have stood down after the high command asked me to do so. I will remain in active politics and fight communal forces till my last breath. The high command asked me to go to the

Rajya Sabha. But with humility, I have told them that I am not interested in national politics," said Mr. Siddaramaiah, who entered politics in the local body elections in 1978. "I owe my career to the Constitution drafted by the committee chaired by B.R. Ambedkar."

Mr. Siddaramaiah, the State's longest serving Chief Minister, said he would serve the remaining two years as a legislator.

The announcement brings to an end the speculation over leadership that has plagued the government for nearly a year and is expected to end public posturing by both factions.

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NEARBY



Former AIADMK Tourism Minister joins ruling TVK

CHENNAI
Vellamandi Natarajan, who had served as the Tourism Minister during the erstwhile AIADMK government in Tamil Nadu, has joined the TVK. **» PAGE 4**

TB death rates decline in six districts in State

CHENNAI
Tuberculosis death rates have declined in six districts after the rollout of the *Kasanoi Erappila Thittam*. **» PAGE 4**

FRIDAY REVIEW » 4 PAGES

'Iran, U.S. to extend truce in tentative deal'

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

Negotiators from the U.S. and Iran reached a tentative agreement on Thursday to extend the ceasefire in the 3-month-old war by 60 days and launch talks on Iran's nuclear programme, according to a U.S. official familiar with the matter while noting that U.S. President Donald Trump has yet to sign off on it.

While Tehran did not immediately confirm any deal, Iran's *Tasnim* news agency, citing a source close to the negotiating team, said that the text of a potential memorandum of understanding (MoU) had not yet been finalised or confirmed, and that reports from Western sources making such claims were false.

The possibility of an

MoU comes as the fragile ceasefire appeared to be wavering. The latest flare-up in fighting happened less than a day earlier, when Kuwait intercepted missiles fired from Iran, according to U.S. Central Command.

According to the U.S. official, who spoke on condition of anonymity, the MoU makes clear that Iran will not be able to impose tolls on the Strait of Hormuz and that it will have to remove all mines from the vital waterway within 30 days. The U.S., meanwhile, would gradually lift its naval blockade on the strait and also agree to relax sanctions, allowing Iran to sell more of its oil, the official said.

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SC sets aside ₹202-crore CCI penalty on Amazon

Krishnadass Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has set aside a Competition Commission of India (CCI) order revoking Amazon's buy-in of 49% stake in Future Coupons in a 2019 combination.

The court also rescinded a ₹202-crore penalty on Amazon by the competition regulator.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta, in a judgment, held that enforcement by the regulator must protect competition without undermining market confidence. The court also said that fair treatment of foreign investors did not mean special treatment.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 11

We will never compromise on State's rights, says Higher Education Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The rights of the State were of utmost importance and in no condition would they be compromised, Tamil Nadu Higher Education Minister P. Viswanathan said on Thursday.

On the controversy stoked by his statement that the new government need not follow the previous government's policies, particularly regarding the Chief Minister serving as the Chancellor of universities, he said: "Our stand is very clear. The rights of the State are of utmost im-



P. Viswanathan

portance. As an MLA, a Minister, and a citizen of Tamil Nadu, I assert that we will not compromise on this. We are protecting the rights of every citizen of Tamil Nadu and I am aware of this responsibility."

The crux of the statement he made in Madurai

on Wednesday, he said, was that the Chief Minister would take a final decision after conferring with the officials of the department and other Cabinet colleagues. "What I made was a general comment. I did not respond to a particular context," he said.

The Minister's statement invited reactions from across the political spectrum, with the VCK, the CPI, the DMK, and the PMK strongly criticising what they described a surrender of the State's rights.

The issue pertains to the authority to appoint Vice-Chancellors to State-run

universities. Under the DMK government, the Assembly had passed a series of amendments to Acts governing higher education institutions, including the one that transferred the authority of appointing Vice-Chancellors to State-run universities from the Governor to the Chief Minister.

"We are a new government. I don't want to go into the details in this matter, but in no way would either the Congress or the TVK surrender the rights of the citizens of Tamil Nadu. That is not our intention," Mr. Viswanathan said.



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INBRIEF



Corporation to expedite work on desilting of canals in city

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has expedited work on desilting canals in various parts of the city. According to a press release, GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran inspected work on desilting of MGR Canal in ward 138 in Kodambakkam zone on Thursday, and ordered officials to expedite the work. He also inspected the work to prevent clogging of the MGR Canal near the Adyar river mouth. He then visited residential areas along the canals and advised the residents to stop dumping of solid waste in the canals.

Text & Context and Health

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (May 29, Friday), the following articles are available:

■ A revival of sedition tied to consent
[newsth.live/revivalofsedition](#)

■ One pair of feet: women, work and TB in Mumbai
[newsth.live/tbwomen](#)

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Fishermen seek support to revive tuna fishing harbour

They urge the State government to build necessary facilities and provide them training to make good use of the harbour, which was constructed in Tiruvottiyur Kuppam at a cost of ₹200 crores

Deepa H. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Fishermen in the city have urged the State government to train them in tuna gill-net fishing and provide loans for the purchase of specialised boats and nets.

If the tuna fishing harbour constructed at a cost of ₹200 crore at Tiruvottiyur Kuppam is to be put to use, fishermen must have the skills to catch quality tuna suitable for export, said M.D. Dayalan of the Indian Fishermen Association.

“In Tamil Nadu, only fishermen from areas near Kanniyakumari know to catch tuna in deep sea. If the fish caught is to be exported, it needs to be processed immediately, which means the boats must have specialised storage facilities. Loans were provided to fishermen in the south to help them buy large boats and encourage them to venture into the deep sea. We need similar sup-



Seeking upgrade: Fishermen said the tuna fishing harbour at Tiruvottiyur Kuppam lacks facilities for pre-processing and post-processing of fish, and waste management. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

port here. The livelihoods of fishermen using the nearby Kasimedu harbour will then see a marked improvement,” said community leader M.E. Raghupathi.

Harbour locked

The harbour, which was envisaged as far back as 2015, was opened for use some time ago, but is currently locked. “Earlier, fishermen from Tiruvotti-

ur Kuppam used to keep their boats at the harbour, but they no longer do so. The breakwaters do not function properly and allow waves to enter the harbour area, causing boats to collide with each other and sustain damage. We do not keep our boats there as the waters are unsafe,” said Joseph, a fisherman from another village. Fishermen said that the harbour lacks facilities such as pre-pro-

cessing, where the innards of the fish are removed, post-processing, and waste management. “Only if the harbour is maintained and equipped with world-class facilities we can obtain export certification. The bane of the Kasimedu Fishing Harbour is the lack of cleanliness. Toilets and drinking water facilities have also not been provided adequately,” said a fisheries industry expert.

Policeman held for sexual harassment of boy in Ashok Nagar

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Ashok Nagar police have arrested a 35-year-old policeman for sexually harassing a minor boy on Thursday.

A senior police official said P. Velappan, a head constable of the Vadapalani police station, along with another person, had gone to his friend's house in Kodambakkam, on Wednesday night and consumed liquor. After getting heavily drunk, the policeman went to the bedroom of the house, where the 15-year-old boy was sleeping.

The boy had accompanied his parents from Nagercoil for a tour to the nearby place and was left to stay in his uncle's house. Seeing the boy being alone, the police head constable attempted to sexually harass the boy. The boy, after fighting-off the inebriated policeman, ran out of the house and complained to police personnel on patrol.

Based on his information, the Ashok Nagar pol-

ice arrested Velappan. A police official said that the head constable was arrested under the POCSO Act and steps were being taken to remove him from service.

Expressing shock over the assault, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said that Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay should focus on maintaining the law and order situation and less on personal appearance and publicity. “The same children you used for campaigning for votes are now without safety in your government. What is your answer for this?” he asked.

AMMK founder T.T.V. Dhinakaran too condemned the incident and urged the TVK-led government to focus on the law and order situation in the State. “If those who are duty-bound to prevent offences are involved in it, how will the rule of law prevail in Tamil Nadu?” he asked.

ChildLine operates a toll-free helpline for children in distress -1098.

The Hindu Tamil Thisai to host ‘Pengal Balam Vazhvathaaram’ event tomorrow

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Hindu Tamil Thisai, in association with Canara Robeco Mutual Fund, will organise a special event titled ‘Pengal Balam Vazhvathaaram’ in Chennai on Saturday focusing on women's financial growth and investment awareness. The programme aims to guide women on financial planning, investment practices, and achieving economic independence through informed savings and mutual fund investments. Women above 21 years of age, who are inter-



ested in learning about mutual funds, can participate in the session. K. Gopinath, National Head (Core Banking Channel and Institutional Sales) and financial expert Soma Valliappan will participate as special guests, and share insights on investment and financial management. According to the organisers, the event forms part of The



K. Gopinath



Soma Valliappan

Hindu Tamil Thisai's continuing series of public outreach programmes conducted across different sectors. The event will be held at Samavesh Hall in Saveria Hotel, on Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, Mylapore, from 4 p.m. onwards.

A hi-tea session has also been arranged as part of the programme. Entry to the event is free. Those interested can scan the QR code for registration and may contact 9944029700 for more details.



Corporation rolls out measures to deal with heat wave conditions



GCC has urged residents of the city not to step out of their home during heat wave conditions. M. SRINATH

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has started heat wave preparedness at 754 locations, including 300 hospitals, 397 Amma Canteens and 57 homeless shelters, in the city. The civic body has imparted training for staff to treat heat stroke cases in the city. “GCC has readied medications and drugs for treatment of heat stroke at hospitals, including UPHC, UCHC and UHWC. A total of 1.34 lakh ORS packets is available to GCC centres. All those who visit the GCC centres will get oral rehydration solutions,” said an official. GCC officials have started creating awareness about the heat wave conditions, advising people to

carry an umbrella, wear a cap, and avoid walking or jogging in parks during daytime. Residents have also been advised not to step out of home during heat wave conditions. The Integrated Command and Control Centre will monitor heat wave conditions and provide advisory for residents.

As the impact on children, pregnant women and senior citizens have been reportedly high, officials have suggested measures to prevent heat stroke cases of such residents in each locality. The officials have advised residents to prevent children from visiting playgrounds during the daytime in summer, and permit them only during the morning and evening in the playgrounds and parks.

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The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Velachery police have detained two migrant labourers from Bihar for sexually assaulting a 61-year-

old mentally challenged woman on Thursday. Police said the woman, a resident of Madipakkam, was waiting at the Velachery bus terminus at around 2.30 a.m. on Thursday,

when the suspects approached her and offered a ride home. They took her to a secluded location, sexually assaulted her, and fled. Based on an alert from residents, Velachery

police rescued her and admitted her to the Government Maternity Hospital in Egmore in an unconscious state. Later, the suspects were identified with the help of CCTV footage.

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CPI(M) State secretary P. Shanmugam on Thursday alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah were using the Enforcement Directorate (ED) as a tool for political vendetta against leaders opposed to them, and termed it a violation of democratic norms. Addressing reporters in Erode on Thursday, he referred to the ED raid at the residence of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and said protests against such “illegal actions” would continue. He described the raids as politically motivated actions against the Opposition parties. Referring to the State government’s crop loan waiver announcement, Mr. Shanmugam said TVK president C. Joseph Vijay should fulfil his election promise. Describing the resignation and induction of AIADMK MLAs into the TVK as “unhealthy politics”, he said it amounted to betraying the mandate of the people who had elected them.

Since, the chief organiser of the jallikattu event did not respond or appear before the court, despite the name being printed on the notice, the court directed the Karur Collector not to permit him to act as chief organiser or hold any office-bearer position for conducting jallikattu henceforth.



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Book that captures Srivilliputhur’s many legacies launched

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

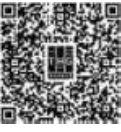
A book on Srivilliputhur, part of The Hindu Group’s ‘Shrine Series’, was re-leased by Nirmala Lakshman, Chairperson, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Limited, in Chennai on Thursday. Suresh Nambath, Editor of *The Hindu*, and Navaneeth L.V., CEO of THG Publishing Private Limited, were present.

The 168-page publication titled *Srivilliputhur - Divine Realm of Andal*, curated by Suganthi Krishnamachari, traces the religious, cultural, and historical significance of the temple town. Located close to Madurai, Srivilliputhur is known for the Andal temple and the Vata-patrasayee temple. The book also features photographs of the temples and festivals, besides illustrations by senior cartoonist Keshav depicting rituals from 8th-Century poet-saint

Andal’s *Varanamayiram* verses. Srivilliputhur is associated with Andal, who was brought up by Periyazhvar and is revered for her *Thiruppavai* verses.

The book also documents other aspects of Srivilliputhur, including the Pennington Library established in 1875, the G.S. Hindu High School where scientist K.S. Krishnan studied before contributing to the discovery of the Raman Effect with C.V. Raman in 1928, and the geographical indication (GI) tag granted to Srivilliputhur palkova.

It also details architectural and artistic features of the temples and Srivilliputhur’s long association with military service. The book containing two posters of Andal and Ranganamannar and Peria Perumal with consorts is priced at ₹699 and is available now with a special launch offer of 30% for a limited period.



After smooth transition, new CM has a delicate task ahead

An immediate challenge for the new CM will be the formation of the Karnataka Cabinet and the allocation of key ministerial portfolios, ensuring contentment and regional and caste balance

Nagesh Prabhu
BENGALURU

Despite an intense power tussle within the Congress in Karnataka over the past three years, the party high command appears to have managed a smooth transition of power to ensure political stability, with Deputy Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar set to succeed outgoing Chief Minister Siddaramaiah.



Power play: When assuming the chair, D.K. Shivakumar must balance ties with Mr. Siddaramaiah loyalists. SUDHAKARA JAIN

Mr. Siddaramaiah has already indicated that he will remain active in politics, raising the possibility of an alternative power centre emerging around him if his supporters feel sidelined under the new leadership.

The outgoing Chief Minister is also expected to play a significant role in decisions concerning the composition of the next State Cabinet and the appointment of a new Karnataka Pradesh Congress

Committee president. (KPCC)

An immediate challenge for Mr. Shivakumar will be the formation of the new Cabinet and the allocation of key ministerial portfolios without triggering resentment among senior leaders, particularly those aligned with Mr. Siddaramaiah.

Ensuring regional and caste balance in Cabinet formation and other appointments is expected to pose another major challenge, given the large number of aspirants within the party. Several senior legislators are already lobbying for ministerial berths and are learnt to have submitted representations to the party high command.

12 arrested over attack on ED team during search at Pinarayi’s residence

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Kerala Police have come under intense scrutiny after the violent attack on Enforcement Directorate (ED) officials during a search at former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan’s residence in Thiruvananthapuram on Wednesday. Allegations of grave intelligence and security failures dominated the fallout from the incident. The Thiruvana-

nthapuram City police have arrested twelve CPI (M) and DYFI workers in connection with the attack thus far. Around 15 people have been identified through television footage, CCTV visuals and intelligence inputs.

Police teams conducted searches at nearly 40 locations, including residences of former Thiruvananthapuram Corporation councilors. The State government has commenced an inquiry

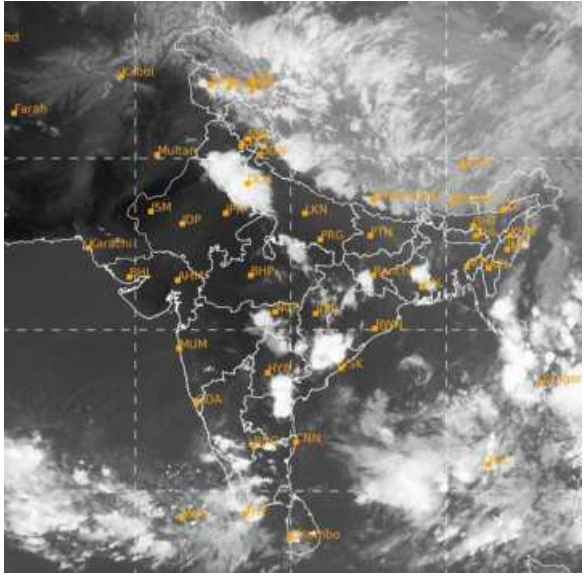
into alleged lapses on the part of the police in anticipating the violence and whether crowd-control measures were inadequate.

High-level meeting
The controversy escalated after senior police and intelligence officials were summoned for a high-level meeting by Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala on Thursday. The meeting was held for nearly 45-min-

utes. State Police Chief after the meeting, said, the police had deployed sufficient personnel and maintained that around 300 police officers were present in connection with the operation. He stated that the ED raid was conducted independently by the central agency and claimed police had not received any specific request for additional security arrangements. (With PTI inputs)

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)

Forecast for Friday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Odisha, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Karaikal, Kerala, Mahe and Andaman & Nicobar Islands. Heat wave conditions likely at isolated places over Telangana, coastal Andhra Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN				
Agartala		48.....	32.0.....	22.2	Kozhikode		14.....	33.5.....	26.4		
Ahmedabad			44.4.....	28.8	Kurnool		0.9.....	37.5.....	26.3		
Aizawl		5.....	30.6.....	19.6	Lucknow			37.4.....	27.3		
Prayagraj			41.0.....	28.2	Madurai			38.2.....	26.6		
Bengaluru			32.4.....	22.8	Mangaluru			32.8.....	25.2		
Bhopal			43.8.....	30.8	Mumbai			34.9.....	29.2		
Bhubaneswar			37.7.....	22.4	Mysuru			33.2.....	22.2		
Chandigarh			40.0.....	25.6	New Delhi			41.1.....	28.4		
Chennai			41.2.....	29.5	Patna			34.7.....	26.2		
Coimbatore			35.0.....	25.4	Port Blair		2.....	31.0.....	24.9		
Dehradun			37.8.....	23.5	Puducherry			38.6.....	28.2		
Gangtok		0.5.....	20.5.....	14.7	Pune			38.1.....	26.2		
Goa			0.4.....	34.8.....	28.0	Raipur			9.....	43.7.....	28.8
Guwahati		0.2.....	30.9.....	23.5	Ranchi				36.4.....	22.2	
Hubballi			33.0.....	24.0	Shillong			1.....	22.1.....	14.0	
Hyderabad			39.6.....	26.8	Shimla				33.1.....	22.8	
Imphal				31.3.....	24.7	Srinagar				29.7.....	14.6
Jaipur				45.4.....	32.8	Thiruvananthapuram			4.....	30.8.....	27.1
Kochi		957.....	29.2.....	25.2	Tiruchirappalli				39.1.....	27.6	
Kohima			26.0.....	17.0	Vijayawada				42.0.....	28.8	
Kolkata		0.3.....	34.8.....	25.4	Visakhapatnam			23.....	34.1.....	24.3	

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	
Ahmedabad		25	68	21		48	 In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Greater Noida
Bengaluru		16	19	39	32		Uttar Pradesh recorded an overall air quality index
Chennai		6	6	40	47		 (AQI) score of 329
Delhi		24	135	96	185	265	 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Samastipur,
Hyderabad		14	15	31	63	83	 Bihar recorded a healthy AQI score of 21
Kolkata		8	24	32	57	92	
Lucknow		6	47	55	105	120	
Mumbai		12	110	26	24	37	
Pune		24	56	33	52		
Visakhapatnam		5	22	17	44	95	

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

WHEN CONFLICTS BRING UNCERTAINTY

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Dr Amit Malik
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Secretary, Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology



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Validating flaws

The Supreme Court should have scrutinised the SIRs problematic record

The Supreme Court’s verdict on Wednesday upholding the ECI’s SIR of the electoral rolls as “an advancement towards free and fair elections” arrives long after the SIR became a settled fact in Bihar and the exercise carried out in 12 other States and Union Territories in phase 2. For months, the Court refused to weigh in on the constitutionality of the exercise, in *Association for Democratic Reforms vs ECI*, and proceeded instead with administrative and managerial decisions. The impact of an unimpeded exercise was a net trim of the rolls by more than 10%, with nearly 6.5 crore deletions and, crucially, an unexplained and curious fall in the gender ratio in the rolls of most States except Tamil Nadu. In West Bengal, the flaws of the SIR led to arbitrary deletions and the systematic exclusion of a large section of minorities and the underprivileged, with statistical exercises indicating that this influenced poll outcomes in many constituencies. The Court’s interventions on the SIR remained largely supervisory until Wednesday, when it delivered a judgment that can only be called a retrospective validation of the process.

It has at last decided the constitutional question, and decided whether the SIR was proportionate and free of arbitrary exclusion as implemented. But it did not adequately confront the record of the implementation. Its reasoning engages the SIR in theory rather than its practice. To the petitioners’ contention that Section 21(3) of the Representation of the People Act authorises only targeted, constituency-specific revision and not a State-wide dragnet, the Court held that the word “any” cannot be read down to “only,” and that a systemic problem of migration and churn needed to be remedied systematically. But it overlooked that Section 21(3) is an exceptional power that omits the “prescribed manner” safeguard binding ordinary roll revisions. On the objection that requiring crores of already-enrolled electors to prove their eligibility afresh inverts the presumption that those electors are valid, the Court offered a distinction between an “adjudicatory” exercise, where that presumption holds, and an “inquisitorial” one, where it does not. The prior judgment in *Lal Babu Hussein* (1995), which had insisted that any removal be reasoned and individuated, was confined to its own facts. Yet, the Court’s assurance that the presumption survives is not borne out when the SIR requires the elector to prove an entitlement already held. An accurate roll, as the Court rightly argues, is the foundation of a genuine election. This is why the potentially wrongful deletion of lawful voters through a hurried process under a demanding election-driven deadline hits electoral integrity.

Quantum-safe thinking

India must be alive to challenges posed by advanced encryption algorithms

The new DST Task Force report on making India’s digital ecosystems quantum-safe is a product of contemplating a threat that is both long-term and urgent. Today, public-key cryptography underpins online identity protection and secure communications. Its protective ability rests on mathematical problems that conventional computers cannot solve efficiently; thus, the information is ‘hidden’ behind a lock whose key is the solution to such a problem. However, a sufficiently capable quantum computer could use, say, Shor’s algorithm to open this lock in minutes or hours. Symmetric cryptography, such as AES encryption, is less threatened by the advent of quantum computers but the existential exposure is nonetheless concentrated in public-key infrastructure, which secures everything from HTTPS to telecommunication networks. The shorter-term problem is the possibility of a bad actor harvesting encrypted data today and decrypting them later using quantum computers. Post-quantum cryptography (PQC) is software that can run on conventional computers but with the added benefit of resisting attacks from quantum computers. The DST report recommends three post-quantum standards finalised in 2024 to plan India’s efforts on the post-quantum effort and that it begin migrating to this architecture. This prudent advice must be followed, especially *vis-à-vis* critical infrastructure, financial services, power grids, and defence.

The migration must continue even if “Q-day” – when quantum computers practically endanger public-key cryptography – is pushed back from the report’s expected 2029. Indeed, experts disagree on this point, although the mainstream view is that both “Q-day” and migration will take at least a decade. Cryptography is in practice a set of dependencies often spread across – within, say, a ministry – databases, legacy hardware, vendor software, authentication protocols, and control systems. Thus, the challenges of the sprawling organisational transition must not be underestimated. Moreover, since advanced AI can autonomously compromise the software layer today and quantum computers threaten the mathematics of encryption tomorrow, the threat surface is much larger than what “Q-day” alone portends. The report recommends the wider adoption of PQC and, in environments requiring higher security assurances, the more technically demanding quantum key distribution (QKD) as well. For India, that means a new budgetary allocation of at least ₹5,000 crore; upgrading legacy infrastructure for interoperability; rationalising vendor dependence; and fostering and retaining the human capital, as QKD engineers are rare today. India must also periodically reassess its needs considering the acute trade-off QKD poses between security and operational efficiency.

The recent discovery of hundreds of cow carcasses at a dumping site in Jaisalmer, Rajasthan, rightly triggered an outrage on social media. A few years ago, a similar incident involving the mass starvation deaths of cows was reported from Chhattisgarh. The new Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in West Bengal issued a public notice on May 13, 2026, laying down stringent conditions for the slaughter of animals under the West Bengal Animal Slaughter Control Act, 1950.

Last week, a two-judge Bench of the Calcutta High Court upheld the notice, observing that the conditions mentioned in the impugned order were issued in compliance with the High Court’s order of August 16, 2018. Consequently, no cow, bull, bullock or even buffalo can be slaughtered without first obtaining a “certificate of fitness” from government officials. Despite all the rhetoric, the notification permitted the slaughter of cows older than 14 years, which justifiably annoyed Hindutva supporters.

Over 20 States in India have laws prohibiting cow slaughter. Only Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Sikkim, Tripura, Manipur, Mizoram and Kerala do not have such laws. But what is the efficacy of these laws? Have the stringent provisions and enhanced punishments introduced over the last 12 years helped preserve cows, or could such laws ultimately contribute to their decline? Whether cow reverence constitutes an essential Hindu practice and whether such laws violate the right to privacy are issues that require a ruthlessly objective assessment.

Politics, faith and cows

Cow protection has long been a central Hindutva issue and which explains the contents of the Bengal notice. Yet, the Congress too has historically benefited from cow protection campaigns. Viceroy Lord Lansdowne famously observed that the cow protection movement had transformed the Indian National Congress from “a foolish debating society into a real political power”. The cow and calf were the Congress’s symbols for decades. Whenever the BJP comes to power in a State, amending cow slaughter prohibition laws to make them more stringent – by enhancing punishments, criminalising possession of beef, and restricting the transport of cattle within or outside the State – becomes a priority. The Gujarat law of 2017 even provides for life imprisonment, and in 2025, three persons were reportedly sentenced to this extreme punishment, ordinarily reserved for heinous offences such as murder, terrorist acts and dacoity. True, cow reverence among Hindus is ancient and enjoys near-unanimous acceptance, though scholars such as D.N. Jha have disputed this assertion citing scriptural material. He pointed to instances in *Dharmashastra* traditions where Yajnavalkya appears to endorse the consumption of beef, and highlighted the inconsistencies and polymorphic nature of Indian dietary practices. He also argued that the “holy” status accorded to the cow was largely a much later development, and noted that several



Faizan Mustafa

Vice-Chancellor,
Chanakya National
Law University,
Patna, Bihar



Abdul Samad

Former Dean, Mumbai
Veterinary College

Politics and
sentiment
continue to
overshadow
realities of
cattle
preservation
in India

prescriptive Hindu texts classified cow slaughter as a minor sin (*upapataka*) rather than a major offence (*mahapataka*). Strikingly, even the prominent Hindutva ideologue Vinayak Damodar Savarkar held views that differed significantly from those of many present-day Hindutva activists. Consequently, cow reverence may not satisfy the parameters of the essential religious practices test which requires practice to be mandatory from the time of origin of a religion.

In *Mohd. Hanif Quareshi vs State of Bihar* (1958), the Supreme Court of India rightly held that cow slaughter on Bakr-Eid is not an essential Islamic practice either. Several Muslim rulers had also restricted cow slaughter. Babur advised Humayun to do so in his will, Jahangir’s Edict No. 10 too prohibited animal slaughter on certain days out of respect for Hindu and Jain sentiments. The influential Deoband Islamic seminary too issued multiple fatwas discouraging cow slaughter. Even in the Constituent Assembly debates on November 24, 1948, Muslim members such as Z.H. Lari and Mohammad Saadullah insisted that “it is better to come forward and incorporate a clause in fundamental rights that cow slaughter is henceforth prohibited, rather than it being left vague in the directive principles....”

What cattle census data reveal

Dr. B.R. Ambedkar eventually placed cow protection within the non-judiciable Directive Principles under Article 48 of the Constitution, following which several States enacted laws after Independence prohibiting cow slaughter. Yet, cattle census data suggest that the objective of preserving and increasing the cow population has not been achieved. West Bengal, for instance, was among the few States where culling and sale of cows and bulls were not entirely prohibited. By conventional logic, its cow population should therefore have been far lower than that of States such as Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra. However, since 1951, the cow population in the country has grown by only 49.63%, while the buffalo population has risen by 153.8% and the female buffalo population by 161.9%. The figures speak for themselves: cows face the risk of decline.

Ironically, the unprotected buffalo population has grown far more rapidly, especially in the so-called cow-belt States. A comparison of cattle growth rates shows that West Bengal, despite lacking stringent cow slaughter laws, has performed better than States with strict prohibitions. Even though male cattle are protected in these States, their population has declined sharply – by 38.3% in Gujarat, 31.4% in Maharashtra and 58.27% in Uttar Pradesh. In contrast, the decline in male cattle population in West Bengal was only 22.8%. The data also suggest that stringent prohibition laws may be pushing farmers in these States towards buffalo rearing, reflected in the declining cattle-to-buffalo ratio between 2012 and 2019. In West Bengal, by contrast, buffaloes remain insignificant in number and their population sharply declined in

Brinkmanship in the age of growing conflict

Iran’s closure of the Strait of Hormuz and the blockade by the United States of Iranian ports are among several recent acts of brinkmanship. A legacy of the Cold War era, brinkmanship refers to single action or a series of actions during a conflict or a short-of-war situation that forces a perilous climb up the escalation ladder to force the adversary to back down, make concessions, negotiate or even do something irrational that would justify the use of uncalibrated or widespread use of force. Coined by western political scientists in the 1950s and 1960s while analysing crises such as the Berlin Blockade (1948-49) and the Cuban Missile Crisis (1962), the term also warned of the risk of escalation spiralling out of control, particularly in the nuclear context (Armageddon).

The return of brinkmanship

With the vast spread of the spectrum of conflict in the post-Cold War era without the disappearance of the nuclear overhang, brinkmanship has once again assumed dangerous proportions and merits some examination in a contemporary context. Terrorism has emerged as a principal instrument of brinkmanship, frequently used by non-state actors to provoke disproportionate state responses and gain international attention and sympathy in pursuit of larger goals. Without debating the dilemma posed by the proposition that argues, ‘One man’s terrorist is another man’s freedom fighter’, globally proscribed terrorist movements have rarely achieved their stated aims through brinkmanship – al Qaeda and the Islamic State being among them. A few such as the Irish Republican Army (IRA) and the FLN (National Liberation Front) in Algeria did force the more powerful adversary to make concessions.

Another flavour of brinkmanship that has emerged in recent decades is proxy brinkmanship of the kind that Pakistan and Iran have engaged in for the last four decades against



Arjun Subramaniam

Military historian and
a strategic analyst

The growing
reliance on
brinkmanship
threatens an
already fragile
global order

stronger powers. Using proxies largely designated as global terrorist outfits, this brand of asymmetric brinkmanship seeks to erode the resolve and power of stronger powers and force them to make concessions over long-festering issues of statehood and sovereignty. The attacks by Hamas on Israel on October 23, 2023, are an example of this kind of brinkmanship. Israel’s disproportionate counter-brinkmanship in Gaza in pursuit of destroying Hamas is testimony to the breakdown of deterrence and the propensity to climb the escalation ladder at breakneck speed to achieve difficult strategic outcomes.

Rising geopolitical tensions

Among the larger powers today, the U.S. has seldom resorted to brinkmanship and prefers instead to achieve its geopolitical objectives through the brute and direct application of force or economic coercion. Frustrated at its inability to drag Iran to the negotiating table, the U.S. has resorted to brinkmanship by imposing a blockade on Iran, hoping to squeeze it economically and make it come to the negotiating table. Iran, on the other hand, has resorted to its own brand of asymmetric counter-brinkmanship that has yielded disproportionate strategic outcomes by blocking the Strait of Hormuz. Where this will go is anybody’s guess until both the parties agree to meet mid-way – such are the complications of the brinkmanship game.

Russia’s brinkmanship, driven by frustration over its inability to halt the North Atlantic Treaty Organization’s eastward expansion despite Moscow’s takeover of Crimea in 2014, and by expectations that Ukraine would capitulate after the advance on Kyiv in February 2022, has instead resulted in a prolonged war. Russia’s periodic sabre-rattling over nuclear restraint is also a legacy of the Cold War that Russian President Vladimir Putin wants to keep alive. The indiscriminate use of hypersonic and other area

2019. In 1997, the cattle to buffalo ratio was 144:1 but in 2019 it became 295:10. In Uttar Pradesh, the cattle-to-buffalo ratio fell from 105:100 in 1997 to 56:100 in 2019. West Bengal, despite lacking stringent prohibitions, witnessed a comparatively stronger growth in cow population and, therefore, mere laws will not protect cows.

Cattle populations grow in a compounded manner because, unlike humans, a cow gives birth to its first calf at around three years and, to remain productive, must calve every 14-16 months. Calves born during a census period also mature and begin reproducing within a few years. According to growth forecasting models, if no cattle were culled or slaughtered and all calves survived except for natural deaths, the cattle population would increase by 2.5 to three times within five years – something that has never occurred in any State. Such growth is economically unsustainable, as farmers cannot support such numbers due to fodder scarcity.

Undermining the farmer

When farmers are legally allowed to exercise their judgment in culling unproductive cattle, they earn additional income to meet expenses such as weddings, children’s education and health care. According to simulation models, farmers in West Bengal earned nearly ₹35,000 crore between 2012 and 2019 from the lawful sale of cattle for slaughter, apart from their dairy income. Farmers in States with strict prohibition laws also appear to have sold cattle for slaughter as is reflected in declining cattle populations, but likely to have earned far less because of the illegality of such sales and the possibility of bribery and middlemen. In effect, these laws do not penalise butchers or beef consumers, but farmers themselves. West Bengal appears to have recognised this reality with Muslim refusal to purchase cows for Eid slaughter. In India’s agrosilvopastoral economy, livestock remains a vital component of rural livelihoods.

In the privacy judgment of *K.S. Puttaswamy* (2017), Justice J. Chelameswar had observed “I do not think that anybody would like to be told by the State as to what they should eat or how they should dress or whom they should be associated with either in their personal, social or political life.” Justice Chandrachud said that what one eats is one’s personal affair and it is a part of privacy under Article 21, i.e., right to life and personal liberty. In view of the politicisation of the issue, Muslims in Bengal prudently refrained from cow slaughter during Eid. One hopes that this will promote social harmony and counter communal hate campaigns. Maulana Arshad Madani, president of the Jamiat Ulama-e-Hind (Arshad Madani faction), has also called for the cow to be declared the national animal. The first writer of this article, though not a veterinary expert, believes that Muslims across India should support a central law banning cow slaughter and imposing stringent punishment, especially on those who sell cows for slaughter.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Top court on SIR

The Supreme Court upholding the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls as the ‘Election Commission’s constitutional duty’ (Front page, May 28) is along expected lines. While

deleting the names of illegal migrants may help cleanse the system, there have also been reports of genuine voters missing from the electoral rolls. Is the Election Commission not answerable for depriving genuine voters of exercising

their franchise? Transparency is key, and all seeds of doubt must be dispelled.

Balasubramaniam Pavani,
Secunderabad

In any vibrant democracy, the sanctity of the electoral

process rests upon the accuracy and integrity of the voters’ list. Such periodic scrutiny not only enhances electoral transparency but also fortifies public confidence in democratic institutions. Nevertheless, the process

must be conducted with diligence and sensitivity so that no eligible citizen is disenfranchised owing to technical or procedural shortcomings. comprehensive public awareness, simplified verification procedures, and

an effective grievance redress system are indispensable to achieving this objective.

Nagarajamani M.V.,
Hyderabad

Letters emailed to
letters@thehindu.co.in
must carry the postal address.

Will increasing the strength of the SC solve the pendency problem?

NOTEBOOK

How plurality and democracy go hand in hand

A tour of Kerala covering the recent elections revealed how issues of multi-ethnic groups rarely take up space in the State's conscience

S. Anandan

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Iridescent streak

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO MAY 29, 1976

Red Indian chief's prevision of ecological disaster

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MAY 29, 1926

Emigration to Malaya

From Page One

Siddaramaiah resigns, leading to power shift



Supporters of Siddaramaiah gather outside his residence as he resigned from the post of Karnataka CM. PTI

The leadership transition is learnt to have been implemented to honour an apparent power-sharing agreement between the two brokered by the high command in May 2023.

The 77-year-old Mr. Siddaramaiah, hailing from Mysuru district, had been asked to pave way for a new Chief Minister on Tuesday.

During the press conference on Thursday afternoon, he thanked Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi multiple times for the opportunities he got after joining the Congress in 2006 following his expulsion from the former Prime Minister H.D. Deve Gowda-led Janata Dal (Secular). Often credited with stitching together an Other Backward Class-Dalit-Muslim social alliance known by the Kannada acronym AHINDA, Mr. Siddaramaiah has been a formidable mass leader over the last decade and half.

This was his second term in office – the first was from 2013 to 2018 and the second began in May 2023. On January 7, 2026, he became the longest-serving Chief Minister of the State, going past the 2,792-day record previously held by Congress leader D. Devaraj Urs. He also served as the Leader of the Opposition on two occasions – between 2008-2013 and 2019-2023.

Earlier in the day, Mr. Siddaramaiah – despite pressure from his followers to continue in the post – announced his resignation during the breakfast meeting of his Cabinet colleagues. He is learnt to have expressed satisfaction over his governance and the challenges that the government faced and thanked his Cabinet colleagues for their cooperation. Adding a twist to the fast-paced political developments was the absence of the Governor as the government had sought his availability on Thursday. However, Mr. Siddaramaiah decided to submit his resignation to the Special Secretary.

Iran, U.S. to extend truce in tentative deal

Among the first issues to be negotiated during the extended ceasefire is what will happen to Iran's highly enriched uranium, the official said.

Iran has not publicly committed to giving up the stockpile, which is believed to be buried under a trio of nuclear sites that were badly damaged by U.S. air strikes last year.

A second U.S. official, who also spoke on condition of anonymity, said the broad outlines of an agreement have been reached but stressed that until Mr. Trump signs off on it, there is no deal. The official said there still are questions about whether Mr. Trump will accept the proposal.

Kuwait had earlier announced an attack on its territory, and Iran said it had retaliated for strikes earlier in the week by firing on a U.S. base in a Gulf state it did not name. The Kuwaiti Foreign Ministry condemned Iran for what it called “blatant aggression,” and U.S. Central Command called the attack on one of America's top allies in the Persian Gulf an “egregious ceasefire violation”. The exchange unfolded after U.S. officials said on Wednesday that U.S. forces launched more strikes on Iran, shooting down four one-way attack drones that posed a threat around the strait and hitting an Iranian ground-control station in Bandar Abbas that was about to launch a fifth drone.

India, China hold talks on border delimitation

According to the MEA, the two sides reviewed the situation along the border and expressed satisfaction over the progress made in maintaining peace and tranquillity in border areas

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

The 35th meeting of the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs (WMCC) was held in Beijing on Wednesday, where India and China held constructive and forward-looking discussions on border delimitation and boundary management issues.

The Indian delegation was led by Sujit Ghosh, Joint Secretary (East Asia), while the Chinese delegation was headed by Hou Yangqi, Director-General of the Boundary and Oceanic Affairs Department of the Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), the two sides reviewed the situation along the India-China border and expressed satisfaction over the progress made in maintaining peace and tranquillity in border areas, which they said had contributed



Fruitful talks: Representatives from India and China at the 35th WMCC meeting held in Beijing on Wednesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

to the gradual normalisation of bilateral relations.

During the talks, both countries discussed issues related to border delimitation, border management, mechanism building and cross-border cooperation.

The Indian side also stressed the need for an early meeting of the Expert Level Mechanism on Trans-border Rivers, it said.

India and China agreed to continue regular diplomatic and military-level exchanges through existing mechanisms, including those agreed upon during

Indian side called for an early meeting of the Expert Level Mechanism on Trans-border Rivers

the 24th Special Representatives (SR) Talks. Both sides agreed to work together for preparations for the next SR meeting, scheduled to be held in China.

On the sidelines of the visit, the head of the Indian delegation met Liu Jin-song, Director-General of the Department of Asian Affairs of the Chinese Fo-

Won't take legal action if infiltrators go back on their own: Shah

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said the Union government had constituted a high-level committee on demographic change and was committed to identifying and deporting every infiltrator from the country.

He said infiltrators should return on their own and those who voluntarily go back would not face any legal action.

Mr. Shah made the remarks in Gujarat as he laid foundation stones for development projects worth ₹340 crore in Gandhinagar.

He said that ever since the BJP came to power in West Bengal “infiltrators have started returning on their own.”

Border fencing

The Home Minister said the BJP government in West Bengal had fulfilled its promise of providing land for border fencing



Amit Shah

within 45 days of coming to power.

Mr. Shah said West Bengal Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari handed over 600 hectares of land to the Border Security Force (BSF) within seven days of coming to power. He added that 121 hectares of land for the Chicken's Neck Corridor had also been handed over to the Centre.

Mr. Shah said that during the rule of the previous government in Bengal, infiltration used to take place every day, but now infiltrators had started returning on their own. The West Bengal government had now established detention centres, he said.

PM calls for cooperative resolution of water disputes

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has asked States to resolve inter-State water disputes through cooperation, timely clearances and technology-based monitoring. The Ken-Betwa project should serve as a model for the same, he said.

Mr. Modi chaired the 51st PRAGATI meeting, where seven critical infrastructure projects across railways, power and road sectors covering nine States were reviewed on Wednesday.

He said that delay in implementation of projects leads not only to cost escalation but also deprives citizens of timely access to essential facilities.

The Hindu, Galgotias University set up Centre for Excellence in Journalism

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Hindu Group Publishing Pvt. Ltd. and Galgotias University have entered into a collaboration to establish The Hindu Centre for Excellence in Journalism on the university campus in Greater Noida.

The initiative seeks to provide journalism and visual communication students with stronger newsroom exposure, editorial mentorship, field engagement, and practical learning opportunities.

As part of the partnership, select students of Galgotias University will gain access to internship opportunities with The Hindu's editorial teams, collaborative publishing opportunities for visual communication projects, curated



The partnership between The Hindu and Galgotias University will give students practical learning opportunities. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

workshops, field visits, and structured interventions by media professionals.

The programme will provide students access to The Hindu newspaper, digital platforms, archives, webinars, and special publications to deepen their engagement with current affairs, public discourse, and journalistic practice.

The partnership will also include quarterly physical and virtual interventions, a journalism course, and immersive field visits allowing students to observe newsroom processes, editorial workflows, and media operations closely.

The memorandum of understanding (MoU) was

signed by Nitin Kumar Gaur, Registrar, Galgotias University, and Sridhar Aranal, Chief Sales and Distribution Officer, The Hindu Group, on Wednesday.

Present on the occasion were K. Mallikharjuna Babu, Vice-Chancellor, Galgotias University; Neha Jindal, Dean, School of Media and Communications Studies, Galgotias University; Anurag Pandey, Assistant Professor, School of Media and Communication Studies; and Sunil Mirza, General Manager, Sales and Distribution, The Hindu Group.

WFI moves SC against HC order allowing Vinesh in trials

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) has moved the Supreme Court challenging the Delhi High Court's order allowing wrestler Vinesh Phogat to participate in the selection trials for the Asian Games 2026. A Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe is scheduled to hear the plea on Friday.

On May 22, a Division Bench of the High Court had allowed the participation of Ms. Phogat in the upcoming trials, saying the WFI's selection policy was exclusionary for the lack of discretion to consider an iconic player like her, who is returning from a maternity break.

Manipur CM visits Naga camp, promises to trace hostages

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on Thursday visited a relief camp housing Nagas displaced by the ongoing ethnic conflict and assured them that the six Naga men missing since May 13 would be traced soon.

The relief camp at the Makhen Baptist Church in Makhan Naga village currently shelters 35 Nagas from Konsakhul. Both villages are in the Kuki-dominated Kangpokpi district.

Armed Kuki groups allegedly abducted some Nagas men from Konsakhul after unidentified gunmen killed three Thadou church leaders between Kotlen and Kotzim villages in Kangpokpi district on May 13. Elsewhere, Naga groups allegedly held Kuki villagers hostage.

An official statement said that among the internally displaced persons the Chief Minister met at the relief camp were women and children who were taken hostage but later released by armed militants. “The government



Manipur CM Yumnam Khemchand Singh visiting a Naga relief camp. PTI

is taking the hostage issue seriously, and the security forces are conducting search and combing operations to locate the hostages,” the statement quoting the Chief Minister said.

He also said that four people suspected to be involved in the kidnapping of the six Naga civilians, including two church leaders, had been arrested.

Not far away in Kangpokpi district's Taphou Kuki village, the families of 14 people allegedly abducted by Naga extremists intensified their protest, demanding equal attention from the government to the hostage crisis they have been facing.

Nearly 1,200 fishing harbours to be brought under CISF watch: Centre

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Nearly 1,200 fishing harbours and fishing landing sites are all set to be brought under the oversight of the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) as part of the Union Home Ministry's plan to secure India's coastline.

A senior government official said that after assigning the security-related duties at around 250 sea ports to the CISF, the Ministry proposes to bring the fishing harbours and landing sites under the supervision of the force.

“It is not possible to deploy CISF personnel at all the fishing harbours but the CISF will be roped in to design the security template and guide the local administration in managing the security protocol. From regulating the movement of fisherfolk through biometric attendance system to providing smart ID cards, the CISF can provide an overall framework,” said the official.



Earlier, to strengthen coastal security, Centre designated the CISF as the security regulator for over 250 seaports. JOTHI RAMALINGAM B

At present, there are a total of 1,547 notified fish landing centres and fishing harbours in 13 coastal States and Union Territories of West Bengal, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Kerala, Karnataka, Goa, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Daman and Diu, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, and Lakshadweep.

The fishing sites are managed both by the State and Union governments. While the States are responsible for post-construction management, maintenance, and operation of the fishing harbours under

their control and have arrangements for management of these harbours, those under the control of the Centre are under the aegis of Port Trusts, the Ministry of Fisheries informed the Rajya Sabha on December 17, 2025.

Uniform security

The official said that there are multiple security agencies deployed along the coastline, starting from the local police to Indian Coast Guard and Indian Navy further in the sea.

“As there are multiple agencies involved, a uniform security template is

missing. The CISF can be used to plug the gaps and also sensitise the local population to coastal security,” the official added.

In December 2025, Union Home Minister Amit Shah convened a meeting for the constitution of a dedicated body, the Bureau of Port Security, for the security of vessels and port facilities. The body, on the line of the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security, is still in the making.

Earlier, to plug the gaps in coastal security, the Union government designated the CISF as the security regulator for over 250 seaports in the country. Officials said that the government intends to deploy “sovereign entity” also at private seaports which handle cargo, bringing them under the a uniform security architecture.

In 2023, following deliberations at the National Security Strategy Conference, guidelines were issued by the Home Ministry to handle sea-port security.

Shutdown hits Id in Arunachal capital

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

A 24-hour shutdown forced Muslims in Arunachal Pradesh's capital to spend Id-ul-Azha indoors on Thursday. Muslims in the State and the region beyond, especially Assam, observed the festival largely without sacrificing cows.

The Arunachal Pradesh

Indigenous Youth Organisation (APIYO) had called the shutdown to protest alleged government inaction against illegal structures, including mosques, and undocumented migrants.

The local authorities, citing Supreme Court directives, said the shutdown was illegal under Section 163 of the BNSS. A few people linked to it were held.



APPEAL

Baby of Urmil Begum, Manipal Hospitals No. MH018424742, 7 days suffering from type B Arch interruption, large upper muscular VSD HR, BAV – No AS, No AR, Subaortic Area narrowing +, off set of AV valves not visualized, TR Moderate to severe, large PDA BD, severe PAH, good BVE, Child underwent High risk arch repair with VSD closure, TV repair and sub aortic area resection and his in Hospital now. The Estimated cost of the surgery is Rs.10,00,000/-

Please send donation however small by Cheque/D.D./M.O Fav. **Save Poor Lives A/c B/o.Urmil Begum, Our A/c Details: S/B A/c No. 20000913487, S.B.I. R.A. Param, IFSC CODE: SBIN0001855, Please Donate by G-pay No.9884607377, UPI Id: savepoorlives@oksb. Donations are exempted under 80G of I.T.ACT.**

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Session to focus on the rise of TVK at The Hindu Huddle

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The ability of youth movements to galvanise change has been apparent globally, particularly in the South Asian region, in recent years. Some of these movements have been bloody revolutions claiming many lives; others have been bloodless, though they too have delivered shocks to the system.

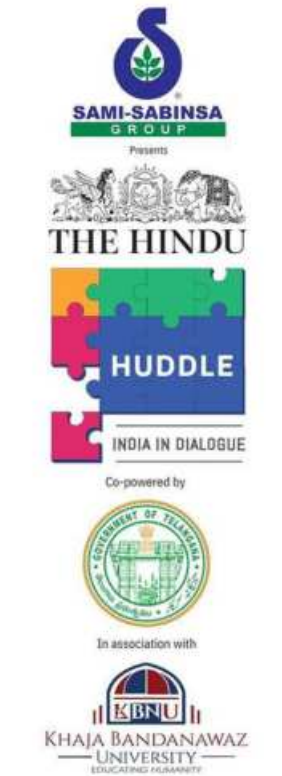
Something of the latter kind happened in Tamil Nadu on May 4. While the result was unexpected for a vast majority of the voters, even those who expected a win for the new party founded by C. Joseph Vijay, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), were surprised, for few anticipated the extent of the win.

The growth of the TVK encapsulates the theme of a session at The Hindu Huddle on June 6 titled “From aspiration to mandate: The Gen Z story”. The Huddle will be held at Taj West End, Bengaluru.

The TVK campaigned like no other party did before this in Tamil Nadu. It used the online space, targeted campaigns aimed at specific groups including women and children, and word of mouth to spread the idea of change.

One of the architects of the TVK win is K.G. Arunraj, a doctor who has worked in the heart of Tamil Nadu. He joined the party in June 2025 after taking voluntary retirement from the civil services.

In this session, he will discuss with Ramya Kannan, Chief of Bureau, Tamil Nadu, *The Hindu*, the



story of the TVK’s astonishing rise, and reveal stories from one of the most spectacular wins on the subcontinent.

The event is presented by the Sami-Sabinsa Group as the Presenting Partner. The event is co-powered by the Government of Telangana and held in association with Khaja Banda Nawaz University. It is further supported by Bank of Baroda, Larsen & Toubro, Apollo Hospitals, IIM Sirmour, ICFAI Group, TAFE, Wizzmoni, Associate Partners; Casagrand, Realty Partner; Toyota, Luxury Car partner; Amity University Bengaluru, University Partner; Harrow International School Bengaluru, Education Partner; Meghalaya Tourism, State Partner; and NDTV 24x7, TV Partner.

Pradhan takes responsibility for lapses in CBSE evaluation

Minister reviews evaluation and post-exam processes, promises a ‘solution to discrepancies in the OSM system’ and says ‘Board is working to address students’ concerns’; also criticises Rahul Gandhi for being ‘opposed’ to technological progress

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

Taking responsibility for the issues that have cropped up with the new on-screen marking (OSM) evaluation process used by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Thursday said that strict action would be taken against anyone found intentionally responsible for irregularities affecting students.

“This was the first time CBSE used [the OSM process], and some discrepancies have come to light. I take responsibility for this and assure you that a solution will be found. We are working on it. We will not leave any student’s query unaddressed,” he said.

Many Class 12 students have alleged scoring discrepancies and also claimed that the scanned copies of their answer sheets uploaded by the Board did not match their handwriting, taking to social media to raise concerns over a possible mix-up in the OSM system.

40 crore pages scanned Under the OSM system, physical answer sheets were scanned and uploaded to a secure digital platform, so that evaluators could assess them on computers instead of handling the paper booklets.

“Seventeen lakh students appeared for the examination, and we have 98 lakh answer sheets. Each answer sheet has 40 pages.



Seeking answers: Members of the National Students’ Union of India during a protest in New Delhi on Thursday against the CBSE over discrepancies in the marking system. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

So, nearly 40 crore pages have been scanned,” Mr. Pradhan said. The CBSE has said that, so far, approximately 4 lakh students have accessed around 11 lakh answer sheets through the portal.

Minister chairs review

“The Board is working to address all concerns raised by students regarding evaluation and re-evaluation for Class 12 examinations,” the Minister said, after chairing a meeting at the CBSE headquarters to address technical and payment-related issues faced by students during the re-evaluation and verification processes.

The review meeting was attended by the Secretary of the Department of School Education, the CBSE Chairperson, and the directors of the Indian Institutes of Technology, Ma-

dras and Kanpur, along with senior officers from the Union Ministry of Education, the Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan, public sector banks and the CBSE.

The CBSE Class 12 evaluation and post-result processes were discussed and reviewed in the meeting. “Mr. Pradhan took note of reports related to login access issues, heavy server load, and payment-related difficulties on the post-examination services portal,” a senior education official noted.

The expert technical team comprising professors from the IIT, Madras and specialists in digital systems has been tasked with reviewing portal stability, server capacity, login management, and payment gateway integration to ensure uninterrupted services for students.

Deliberations focused

on providing a student-friendly re-evaluation portal, strengthening the CBSE’s digital platforms, enhancing student exam and result facilitation mechanisms, and improving evaluation and monitoring systems.

Stakeholders also highlighted measures undertaken for student support and outlined future plans for robust, transparent, and technology-enabled service delivery to benefit students.

The official added that following discussions with the Finance Ministry, the payment gateways of four public sector banks – the State Bank of India, Indian Bank, Bank of Baroda, and Canara Bank – have been integrated with the CBSE portal to make the system more seamless for students.

Mr. Pradhan also

slammed Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi for his remarks on the alleged discrepancies in the CBSE exam system, saying he was “frustrated” and “opposed” to technological progress.

The Minister’s response came a day after Mr. Gandhi had said the CBSE examination results have been marred by “massive irregularities” and demanded an independent judicial inquiry and constitution of a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to unearth the truth behind the “entire scam”. He had also accused the CBSE of handing over the contract for digital evaluation of answer books to a Telangana firm with a murky past.

“Yesterday, CBSE gave its response regarding this matter. It is in accordance with the procurement policy of the Government of India. I want to assure everyone that if any irregularities are found, no one will be spared,” Mr. Pradhan said. He added that the Congress leader appeared “frustrated” due to continuous electoral defeats. “But as far as Rahul Gandhi is concerned, he seems to have reached a different state of mind. Due to continuous electoral defeats, he appears frustrated. He opposed SIR, he used to oppose EVMs, and he opposed Digital India. He does not seem to stand with India’s scientific progress,” he said.

The Minister urged political parties to avoid politicising the issue.

PM should have sacked Pradhan, says Rahul Gandhi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday accused Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan of being “complicit” in the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) decision to award the contract for its new on-screen marking (OSM) system to a controversial firm.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi should have sacked Mr. Pradhan for “ruining the futures of lakhs of students”, Mr. Gandhi said, responding to widespread complaints of irregularities in the new evaluation process.

His remarks came after the Education Minister said Mr. Gandhi was making allegations after facing repeated electoral losses.

“Dharmendra Pradhan ji, you can attack me all you want but it won’t absolve you of your crimes. Nor will it stop me from demanding answers for 18.5 lakh children,” the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha said in a post on X. Mr. Gandhi accused Mr. Pradhan of failing to answer questions relating to the award of the CBSE’s OSM contract to COEMPT, a company that was already “mired in controversy”.

“Either you ran a background check and went ahead anyway – or you didn’t run one at all. Either way, you are complicit,” he alleged.

Mr. Gandhi said accountability ultimately rested with the Prime Minister. “As for responsibility – if the PM cared, he should have sacked you long ago for ruining the futures of lakhs of students,” he said.

HC to hear plea against blocking of CJP’s X handle

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court is scheduled to hear on Friday a petition by the founder of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), Abhijeet Dipke, against the blocking of the satirical digital outfit’s social media account on X. Mr. Dipke’s petition is listed for hearing before Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav.

The original X handle of the CJP was withheld in India on May 21, following which the group resurfaced with a new handle, ‘Cockroach is Back’.

36 regional parties record income decline

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The total income of 36 regional parties dropped by over 51% in the financial year 2024-25. They spent more than they earned, however, with their total expenditure exceeding their combined income by 20%, according to an analysis by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR).

The combined income of the 36 regional parties stood at ₹1,193 crore in 2024-25, down from ₹2,463 crore the previous year, a decline of ₹1,270 crore or 51.6%, the ADR analysis showed.

The total expenditure declared by these parties, however, reached ₹1,433



An aerial view of the crowd at a public rally ahead of the Assembly polls in the Cooch Behar district of West Bengal. PTI

crore, exceeding their consolidated income by ₹240 crore, or about 20%.

ADR analysed the audited accounts of 36 out of 67 recognised regional parties whose annual audit reports for 2024-25 were

available on the Election Commission website.

Top earners

The remaining 31 parties had not made their audit reports available even 207 days after the October 31,

2025 deadline, it said.

The top five parties accounted for nearly 69% of the total income and over 77% of total expenditure among the parties analysed, with the highest income declared by the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) at ₹228 crore, followed closely by the Trinamool Congress at ₹219 crore and the YSR Congress Party at ₹140 crore.

Leading spenders

On the expenditure front, the YSR Congress spent the most at ₹340 crore, followed by the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) at ₹288 crore and the Trinamool at ₹228 crore.

Of the 36 parties, 21 spent more than the income they collected dur-

ing the year, with the YSR Congress topping the list. It spent a whopping 142% more than its earnings, with an excess expenditure amount of almost ₹200 crore.

Other parties which reported expenditure exceeding their income were the Trinamool Congress, the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), the BJD, the Janata Dal (United), and the Samajwadi Party.

There were 15 parties which reported unspent income, with the TDP reporting the largest surplus, retaining ₹167 crore unspent, followed by the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) with about ₹36 crore each.

IAF may oversee transport of papers for NEET-UG re-test

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

The government is considering involving the defence forces to manage logistics and transportation for the NEET-UG 2026 re-test, scheduled for June 21. This measure follows the cancellation of the original test after an alleged question paper leak.

Top sources in the Ministry of Defence confirmed that a high-level meeting was held at the residence of Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, which was attended by Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia. Officers from the Indian Air Force (IAF) were also present during the discussions.

According to officials, a proposal has been prepared to deploy the IAF to provide transportation and logistics support to securely move question papers from printing presses to examination centres

Question papers are currently dispatched via postal network, involving multiple handling points

across the country. The final decision is expected after consultations with the Prime Minister’s Office.

Question papers are currently dispatched via the postal network, which involves multiple handling points and officials.

Sources said the proposed IAF-backed mechanism aims to minimise the risk of leaks and strengthen security protocols.

“IAF will discuss the practical details with officials concerned with the examination to execute the plan if it gets approval from the Ministry,” an official said.

The NEET-UG 2026 examination, originally conducted on May 3, was cancelled by the National Testing Agency (NTA) on May 12.

Siddaramaiah, Nitish and the end of a socialist era

NEWS ANALYSIS

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

The exit of Siddaramaiah from the post of Karnataka Chief Minister, into what could be a political sunset, has a strong echo with what happened with Janata Dal(U) leader Nitish Kumar, not just in the exit routes prescribed but also in the fact that their departures also signal the death of a particular lexicon of socialist politics.

Both former Chief Ministers began their political careers as part of the big socialist rise during the anti-Emergency movement, and both secured their first electoral victories within



Party stalwarts: Former Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah with former Chief Minister of Bihar Nitish Kumar in New Delhi. FILE PHOTO

the socialist frame – Nitish Kumar as an MLA on Janata Party ticket from Har-naut in Bihar in 1985, and Mr. Siddaramaiah as a Lok Dal MLA from Chamundeshwari in 1983.

For many years, the two leaders belonging to non-dominant backward castes

– Nitish Kumar from the Kurmi community and Mr. Siddaramaiah being a Kuruba – worked under the umbrella of socialist parties led by Lalu Prasad in Bihar and H.D. Deve Gowda in Karnataka.

Both refashioned the Mandal maths of OBC con-

solidation in their respective States. In 1994, Mr. Nitish Kumar held a Kurmi conference and formed the Samata Party, carving out the non-Yadav OBC “Luv-Kush” vote bank. He was also the first to identify Pasmanda Muslims as a distinct voter category. Mr. Siddaramaiah broke free from the JD(S)’s Vokkaliga-coded politics and the Deve Gowda family to fashion the AHINDA comprising *Alpasankhyataru* (minorities), *Hindulidavaru* (Backward Classes) and *Dalitaru* (Dalits).

They found space for this refashioning within or in alliance with a national party. The Janata Dal(U) is one of the oldest allies of the BJP (with some diversions along the way), while

Mr. Siddaramaiah joined the Congress after he was expelled from the JD(S) by Mr. Deve Gowda in 2005 for going ahead with AHINDA conventions, which the latter saw as a threat.

Both leaders carried not just the weight of their caste coalitions but also the socialist strain of ideology that has been on a retreat since its high noon in 1977. The growth of the BJP, on the right of the political spectrum, came more at the expense of the socialist strain than of the Congress.

BJP’s rise

With the arrival of Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the national scene in 2014, the BJP too got creative with the caste coalitions

that it drew up, especially in Uttar Pradesh and other north Indian States. Bihar and Karnataka, however, remained immune from any re-engineering by the BJP, but the exit of Mr. Nitish Kumar and Mr. Siddaramaiah has split the politics of their States wide open.

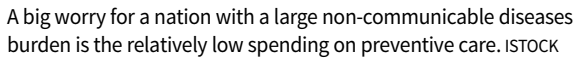
The Janata Dal(S), allying with the BJP, has little chance of recovering the minority vote it lost to Siddaramaiah. It is largely seen as a Vokkaliga party, and will have to battle the Congress for that vote too. In Bihar, the BJP got its first-ever Chief Minister with Mr. Nitish Kumar’s exit, with little chance of the Luv-Kush vote bank moving away from the NDA in any intact way.

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No: DTE/T-4(SCHEME)/PMPES/4324(3)/2026/61241		दिनांक : 23.5.26	
Corrigendum- IX			
ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या 01/2025-26 में निम्नानुसार संशोधन किये जा रहे हैं:-			
S.N.	UBN No.	Corrigendum	
01	UBN No. TET2526SLOB000140; TET2526SLOB000141; TET2526SLOB000142; TET2526SLOB000143; TET2526SLOB000144; TET2526SLOB000145; TET2526SLOB000146; TET2526SLOB000147	RFP में निम्नानुसार आवश्यक संशोधन किये जा रहे हैं- 1. Bid due date -17-06-2026 2. Opening of Technical Bid- 17-06-2026 3. Announcement of qualified bidders- 06-07-2026 4. Opening of financial bid- 13-07-2026 5. Letter of Award (LOA)- Within 30 days of opening of Financial Bid. 6. Validity of Bids- 120 days of Bid Due Date. 7. Signing of License Agreement - Within 30 days of award of LOA.	
अन्य नियम एवं शर्तें पुस्तक संख्या DIPR/C/9316/26			निदेशक (प्रशिक्षण)

At least three people drowned after a country boat carrying 14 passengers capsized in the Ganga in Patna district on Thursday. Patna DM Thiyagarajan S.M. said SDRF and NDRF teams had been deployed and seven people rescued so far even as four are missing. According to the DM's office, 14 residents of Patna district boarded the boat at 5.45 a.m. to reach Samastipur district. "During the return journey, the boat capsized due to strong winds," Mr. Thiyagarajan said.

After drawing a blank in the 2025 Bihar Assembly election, the Jan Suraj Party, led by Prashant Kishor, announced on Wednesday that the party will contest the bypoll to the Bankipur Assembly seat with "full might and strength". The Election Commission is yet to announce the date for the bypoll. The seat had fallen vacant after BJP MLA Nitin Nabin was elected to the Rajya Sabha after being elevated as the party's national president. The buzz is Mr. Kishor might contest the bypoll.

While India has improved public financing of health care, households and individuals still bear the heaviest burden. As per the latest figures from the National Health Accounts (NHA) Estimates for India 2022-23, out-of-pocket expenditure (OOPE) is nearly half of the current health expenditure, and financial protection for health emergencies remains incomplete, though government and insurance spending has increased.



tisation of health in public spending. In per capita terms, GHE has increased nearly 2.7 times... The decadal trend of increased Government Health Expenditure has resulted in overall reduction in the Out-of-Pocket Expenditure (OOPE) as a share of the Total Health Expenditure," the release claims.

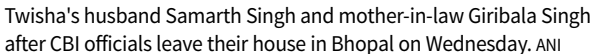
The government's interpretation of the NHA measures and takes credit for infinitesimal growth of public spending. According to a press release, "The share of Government Health Expenditure (GHE) as a percentage of the GDP has risen from 1.15% in 2013-14 to 1.43% in 2022-23", and as per the new GDP series, it will be 1.48% in 2022-23. "Similarly, this share in General Government Expenditure has increased from 3.78% to 4.89% over the same period, underscoring the growing priori-

However, claims notwithstanding, these figures are still short of the WHO Global Recommendation to dedicate at least 5% of the GDP to public health towards meeting universal health coverage targets. It also falls short of National Health Policy recommen-

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Thursday arrested retired Bhopal district judge Giribala Singh in the Twisha Sharma dowry harassment and death case, a day after the Madhya Pradesh High Court rejected the anticipatory bail a local court had granted her on May 15.

Ms. Singh, Twisha's mother-in-law, was questioned for six hours at her house in Bhopal before the arrest, the agency's Chief Information Officer, Beena Yadav, told *The Hindu*. On Thursday morning, several CBI officers arrived at Ms. Singh's residence and carried out an investigation and recreated the crime scene.

Twisha's husband Samarth Singh, a lawyer, is in CBI custody. Ms. Yadav said that Ms. Singh will be



produced before a local court on Friday, and the CBI will seek her custody. The agency plans to confront the mother and son with each other's statements and interrogate them on the circumstances leading to Twisha's death, officials said.

The anticipatory bail was granted just hours after an FIR was lodged by

the local police against Ms. Singh and her son.

Late on Thursday, the single Bench of Justice Devanarayan Mishra issued the order after hearing petitions by Twisha's father Navnidhi Sharma and the State government challenging the bail.

In its observations, the High Court noted that some of the injuries found

on Twisha's body were "not caused due to taking out the body from the ligature or carrying out to the hospital" and that one head injury "was antemortem", suffered before death.

"As per the post-mortem report, the death was due to antemortem hanging by ligature, but from the post-mortem, it is also clear that six other injuries were found in the body of the deceased, in which four injuries were on the left arm, one on the ring finger and one on the head, and that was antemortem," it said.

The High Court observed that the trial court did not consider allegations, presented by the victim's family, against Ms. Singh while granting the anticipatory bail. The observations prompted Twisha's family to reiterate claims that their daughter "was killed".

NEW DELHI

Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing will visit India from May 30 to June 3, the External Affairs Ministry announced on Thursday. This will be the first foreign visit by President Hlaing since he won the controversial election (December 2025-January 2026) that excluded political parties of the Opposition.

The Opposition National Unity Government (NUG) has protested against the announced visit, describing Mr. Hlaing as a “terrorist junta leader” who is attacking Myanmar’s people.

“Myanmar lies at the confluence of India’s neighbourhood First, Act East and MAHASAGAR policies. The official visit of President U Min Aung Hlaing to India is expected to further strengthen and deepen the multi-faceted relations between the two countries,” the Ministry said. The visit will be keenly watched as it comes against the backdrop of intensifying Myanmar mili-



Australian Deputy Prime Minister and Defence Minister Richard Marles will visit India next week to hold talks with Defence Minister Rajnath Singh as part of the second Australia-India Defence Ministers' Dialogue.

The visit will take place after Mr. Marles attends the 23rd Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore, one of the leading defence and security forums in the Indo-Pacific region organised by the International Institute for Strategic Studies (IISS).

In a statement, the Australian government said that during his visit to India, Mr. Marles and Mr. Singh are expected to review bilateral defence cooperation and discuss ways to further strengthen strategic and military ties between the two countries. The dialogue follows the first edition held in Australia last October and reflects growing momen-

tum in the India-Australia defence partnership.

Ahead of the visit, Mr. Marles said, "In a deteriorating strategic environment, the Shangri-La Dialogue provides an important forum to engage with partners on shared challenges."

He further said, "Australia and India are top-tier security partners. I look forward to meeting with Defence Minister Rajnath Singh to further strengthen our defence partnership following the strong progress we made during his visit to Australia last year."

The Agriculture Ministry is taking stock of regions that may see insufficient rainfall during the monsoon, amid El Nino predictions, and preparing advisories on the appropriate crops that ought to be grown, Agriculture Minister Shivaraj Singh Chouhan said on Thursday.

"El Nino is not something to be feared but something that we must prepare for. The India Meteorological Department has not given a final word but we are preparing for it – for instance, if some regions see less rain, what would be the appropriate seeds, the modes of supply and necessary contingency plans. If it comes, we will fight it," he said at the inauguration of the Kharif Conference, which will see the participation of State Agriculture Ministers.

The IMD has forecast a “below normal” southwest monsoon, with the country likely to receive only 92% of the normal rainfall during June-September.

4	2	7	3	6	5	1	8	9
9	8	5	1	7	2	6	4	3
1	6	3	9	8	4	2	7	5
6	4	8	5	1	9	7	3	2
5	1	2	8	3	7	9	6	4
7	7	3	9	4	6	8	5	1
2	7	4	6	9	3	5	1	8
8	5	6	4	2	1	3	9	7
3	9	1	7	5	8	4	2	6

Going on holy pilgrimage is an ancient practice that has never lost its relevance in contemporary times. During His avatar as Krishna, He sported on every inch of land in Mathura, Gokulam and Brindavan, which came to be known as *leelasthalams* and devotees thronged those places. It is even more efficacious when they listen to Bhagavata Sappthaham, (discourses on Srīmad Bhagavatam for seven days), said Damodhara Deekshithar.

The ancient namavali, *Yamuna teera vihara, Brindavan sanchari, Govardhana giridhari, Gopala Kirshna Murari*, is a time-tested salutation: Victory to the Lord who wanders on the banks of the Yamuna and roams in the Brindavan. He is the one who lifted the Govardhan hill; the protector of cows and the destroyer of demons. The namavali is a reference to His favourite places, visiting which will invite divine grace. It is not uncommon to come across devotees who stay in Brindavan for long stretches of time, observing fast, *mouna vrat* and singing bhajans, daily. Scriptures say Brindavan is close to His heart, that He never left it and His presence can be felt there even today. *Brindavanathil oru piravi vendum*, is a famous Tamil saying, paying rich tribute to this aura.

It is recommended that *yatis* (pilgrims) visit Pushkar (Bhagawan is in the form of water here) and spend a few days in Mathura: it is said Krihna's tiny feet touched every square inch of 120 sq km of this town when He lived and herded cows from morning till evening. A subsequent visit to Dwaraka, where Krishna lived with Rukmini after accepting her surrender to Him, is the cornerstone of this bhakti yatra.

INBRIEF



Royal Enfield launches
Bullet 650cc at ₹3.64 lakh

Royal Enfield, has announced the launch of its iconic motorcycle ‘Bullet’ in 650cc capacity in India at ex-showroom price of ₹3,64,856. Paired with a 6-speed gearbox, the Bullet 650’s twin-cylinder platform delivers smooth power and effortless acceleration, suited for both relaxed cruising and spirited riding, the company said. The Bullet 650 will be available in two colours Cannon Black and Battleship Blue.

NHAI identifies 1,600 km for
monetisation for FY27

The National Highways Authority of India said it had identified 17 projects totalling 1,692 km across 9 States for monetisation in the current financial year. These highway assets collectively represent economic and logistics corridors with established traffic potential and robust connectivity significance, the authority said in a statement. The identified projects are across Haryana, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Rajasthan, TN, Telangana, U.P., Bihar, and Maharashtra.

Bajaj Finserv to invest up to
₹2,000 cr. in AI, tech start-ups

Bajaj Finserv on Thursday said it will be investing up to ₹2,000 crore in artificial intelligence and technology-led start-ups in the next five years. The company made the announcement with the launch of ‘Finserv Intelligence’, a strategic initiative in applied research and innovation, focussed on high-tech, low unit-cost, highly scalable solutions, built in India. It has also tied-up with IIT-Bombay to establish a joint research centre. PTI

SC sets aside ₹202-cr.
penalty on Amazon in
Future Coupons case

Apex court rescinds Competition Commission of India order revoking Amazon’s buy-in of 49% stake in Future Coupons in a 2019 combination

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has set aside a Competition Commission of India (CCI) order revoking Amazon’s buy-in of 49% stake in Future Coupons in a 2019 combination. The court also rescinded a ₹202-crore penalty on Amazon by the competition regulator.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta, in a judgment, held that enforcement by the regulator must protect competition without undermining market confidence.

It said the regulator’s interventions to promote market competition must not be compromised by unpredictability or form-driven approaches that did not serve the statutory purpose of the Competition Act, 2002.

The top court said fair treatment of foreign investors did not mean special treatment. “It means equal treatment under the same law, administered through the same procedural safeguards and disciplined reasoning,” Justice Nath, who authored the May 27 judgment, said.

Amazon’s 2019 investment of ₹1,431 crore in Future Coupons, which would give it indirect sway over Future Retail, went



Rule of law: The Supreme Court said that the Competition Act, 2002 “promotes as well as protects”. REUTERS

sour when the Future Group tried to sell its retail assets to Reliance Retail in 2020. Amazon had challenged the move, only to have the CCI suspend its initial approval of the 2019 deal while fining Amazon ₹202 crore on the grounds of “suppression, omission, and misrepresentation” of its perceived larger interests in Future Retail.

The court concluded that the CCI acted outside the statutory authority by withdrawing the approval given to the Amazon-Future Coupons combination in 2019. It said that the CCI had all the “contemporaneous regulatory record”, executed agreements, and connected arrangements while granting approval.

“It was on that record that the CCI undertook scrutiny and granted approval under Section 31(1) of the Act. In these circumstances, a later and more

formal view of how the same material ought to have been described cannot convert an approved filing into a case of non-notification or suppression in substance,” the apex court said.

The court said the Competition Act, a “forward-looking instrument of economic regulation”, and the CCI play key roles in preserving and regulating competitive markets in India. The court said the 2002 Act “promotes as well as protects”.

“The Act is enacted, keeping in view the economic development of the country, to prevent practices having adverse effect on competition, to promote and sustain competition, to protect the interests of consumers, and to ensure freedom of trade carried on by other participants in markets in India,” the court said.

India, Korea agree to
address India’s growing
bilateral trade deficit

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The negotiating teams of India and South Korea concluded the 12th round of negotiations on upgrading the existing trade agreement between the two countries, with South Korea agreeing to address India’s growing bilateral trade deficit, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry said on Thursday.

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and South Korean Trade Minister Yeo Han-koo had in April 2026 signed a joint declaration to accelerate negotiations to upgrade the India-Korea Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (IKCEPA), which had come into force in 2010.

The 12th round of the upgrade negotiations was held in New Delhi on May

The 12th round of
the upgrade
negotiations was held
in New Delhi on May
25-27, 2026

25-27, 2026. “Both sides acknowledged India’s bilateral trade deficit, which has risen significantly since the IKCEPA came into force in 2010, and agreed to address the issue within the overall IKCEPA framework,” the Commerce Ministry said in a statement.

India’s trade deficit with South Korea stood at \$15.6 billion in 2025-26, compared with \$5.1 billion in the financial year ended March 2010. “During the current round, discussions were held on trade in goods, trade in services, rules of origin and origin procedures, investment,

and sanitary and phytosanitary standards,” it added.

The two sides also decided to constitute subgroups to discuss cooperation in the areas of digital trade, supply chain cooperation, and strategic industrial cooperation.

“India and Korea reaffirmed their commitment to conclude the CEPA upgrade negotiations in a time-bound manner, with the objective of achieving a modernised and mutually beneficial agreement that supports the shared vision of balanced bilateral trade and enhanced cooperation,” the statement said.

The negotiations were co-chaired by Kapil Chaudhary, Joint Secretary in the Department of Commerce and Park Geun-oh, Director General for Trade Agreement Policy in the Republic of Korea.

Ashok Leyland Q4 PAT rises 14%;
board declares ₹2.50 dividend

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Ashok Leyland Ltd. reported a 14% growth in fourth-quarter profit after tax (PAT) to ₹1,291 crore from ₹1,130 crore in the same period last year. The profit was attributed to owners of the company.

Revenue from operations increased 17% year

on year (YoY) to ₹17,246 crore. For FY26, the company’s PAT grew 12% YoY to ₹3,471 crore. Revenue from operations grew 16% YoY to ₹56,362 crore.

The board has declared a second interim dividend of ₹2.50 per share. Together with the interim dividend declared and paid during Q3, the overall dividend for the year works

out to ₹3.50 per share. Overall commercial vehicle (CV) volumes scaled a new all-time high of 2,20,437 units, surpassing the previous peak of 1,97,366 units achieved in FY19. The CV volumes in FY26 were up 13% from last year. Light commercial vehicle (LCV) volumes reached 74,322 units from the earlier high of 66,633 units in FY24.

Coal gasification can help
substitute imports of up to
₹3 lakh crore, says Reddy

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI



G. Kishan Reddy

Coal gasification can help substitute imports of up to ₹3 lakh crore, Union Coal Minister G. Kishan Reddy said, adding that the sustainable mining method also extends to ensuring self-reliance for India’s industries and overall economic security.

“Each year, the country imports products valued at up to ₹3 lakh crore that could also be availed via coal gasification,” he said at a promotional roadshow for surface coal and lignite gasification projects, here on Thursday.

Coal gasification entails conversion of coal into syngas, which can be used to produce chemicals, fertilisers and hydrogen.

It was also informed that the government was

working on a policy to include within the broader urea policy – an incentivised component that shall include urea produced via coal gasification.

On May 13, the Union Cabinet had approved the scheme for promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects with a financial outlay of ₹37,500 crore.

Explaining the aspect on ensuring economic security, Mr. Reddy said, “In-

dia is nearly 90% import-dependent for many industrial chemicals. For procuring these essential chemicals, the country spends a lot of foreign currency.”

“Geopolitical tensions, such as the conflict in West Asia which have caused shipping disruptions globally, have also impacted India’s supply chains. Thus, gasification [now] also extends as a subject for strategic industrial, self-reliance, economic security and [the vision for] Viksit Bharat,” he added.

In response to a question from *The Hindu* on the technology for coal gasification, the Minister said it would not be a problem as the government had eased restrictions for import of technology and with private sector collaboration in the realm.

‘Demand for
EVs has risen
amid higher
fuel costs’

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Tata Motors MD & CEO Shailesh Chandra said that the complete effect of the West Asia conflict and the resulting rise in fuel prices on consumer sentiment would become clearer over the next two to three months, though the demand for electric vehicles (EV) had already seen a three-fold jump amid higher fuel costs.

The automaker said it aims to infuse fresh energy into the hatchback segment with the launch of the updated Tiago, as it looks to revive its share in the overall passenger vehicle portfolio after the segment’s contribution slipped to about 15% in recent years. Mr. Chandra was speaking ahead of the launch of the updated Tiago on Thursday.

Foreign institutional investors
continue sell-off, albeit slower in May

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Foreign institutional investors sold ₹34,469 crore in equities as of May 28 2026, according to NSDL data.

This is the fourth month of sell-off in Indian equities in the calendar year, with March 2026 being the third consecutive one.

As of May 2026, foreign investors have pulled out a total of ₹2.26 lakh crore, which makes the five-month period among the worst ever. So far, the highest outflow in a month was

₹1.17 lakh crore in March 2026. Outflows ebbed to ₹60,847 crore in April 2026. India’s dwindling preference as a market among FPIs is visible with the returns of MSCI Emerging Markets Index with Nifty 50.

The MSCI Emerging Markets Index, which is a benchmark for many foreign investors with financial interest in emerging economies, consistently performed better than Nifty 50 in the past five months. Investors in the Indian market received ne-

gative returns in four of the past five months, but the MSCI index had negative returns in just three of them.

The March 2026 loss was at 13.3% for the MSCI Emerging Market Index, more than the 11.3% of Nifty 50, but the former rebounded completely in April 2026, returning 14.5% and maintaining the momentum.

India, however, has not regained this momentum. In April 2026, Nifty 50 return was 7.5%, but this was much lesser than the

11.31% in March 2026.

“Poor earnings growth in India, much better earnings growth and prospects for earnings growth in other markets, high bond yields, particularly in the U.S., and continuous rupee depreciation and fears of further depreciation are the reasons behind the sell-off,” said V.K. Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist, Geojit Investments Limited.

Until these reasons fade, a meaningful FPI rebound is not likely, Mr. Vijayakumar added.

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EAGER TO IMPROVE

‘I want to be a player who bats anywhere and wins matches’



R.V. MOORTHY

Amidst Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's heroics, Dhruv Jurel has quietly gone about his business at No. 3 for Rajasthan Royals in IPL 2026. "Whether I have unlocked my T20 game or not, I can't say. I want to become a player who can bat anywhere. Whatever the situation, I should be able to read the match and win it for my team".

PURE ENTERTAINER

Phenomenal player and new six machine: Gayle on Sooryavanshi



R.V. MOORTHY

Chris Gayle hailed RR opener Vaibhav Sooryavanshi for his sensational 29-ball 97 against SRH in the IPL Eliminator. The knock also saw the teenager overtake Gayle for the most sixes in a single IPL edition (65 to 59). "What a phenomenal player Vaibhav is. Great entertainment young man! New six machine at IPL," wrote Gayle.

IMPRESSIVE SHOW

Jemimah, Yastika slam fifties as India scores 188 in opening T20I



AP

India rode on half-centuries from Jemimah Rodrigues and Yastika Bhatia to reach 188 for seven against England in the opening T20I at Chelmsford on Thursday. The two added 126 for the third wicket. **The scores:** India 188/7 in 20 overs (Yastika Bhatia 54, Jemimah Rodrigues 69, Lauren Bell 3/34) vs England. **Toss:** England.

SETBACK

Venus and Baptiste withdraw from French Open women's doubles



FILE PHOTO

Venus Williams and Hailey Baptiste withdrew from the French Open women's doubles event on Thursday, and no reason was given by the organisers. Baptiste was forced to retire during her singles second-round match against Wang Xiyu on Wednesday after landing awkwardly on her left leg late in the first set.

All eyes on Sooryavanshi as RR, GT seek final berth

If Titans send back the opener early, pressure will be enormous on the rest of the Royals batting unit; Archer holds the key for Parag's men against the top three of Gill, Sai Sudharsan and Buttler

IPL-19

Vivek Krishnan
NEW CHANDIGARH

In the IPL 2026 Qualifier 1 in Dharamshala on Tuesday, Royal Challengers Bengaluru's plan of attack against Gujarat Titans was palpable at the outset. Shubman Gill & Co. appear at ease exhibiting a more traditional template of T20 cricket, but can get dragged out of their comfort zone when circumstances demand a breakneck tempo of scoring.

The RCB top-order attacked Mohammed Siraj and Kagiso Rabada – the pair has often bowled all six overs of the PowerPlay in tandem this season – in the quest to make Titans press the panic button. Skipper Rajat Patidar picked up the baton on the back of a blazing start as RCB amassed 254 for five and clinched a 92-run win.

Rajasthan Royals' Vaibhav Sooryavanshi needs no second invitation to attack up front. When Royals face Titans at the Maharaja Yadavindra Singh Stadium in Qualifier 2 on Friday, therefore, the 15-year-old's duel against the pair of Siraj and Rabada will possibly take centre-stage in shaping the narrative in what is expected to be a sultry evening.

The wunderkind from Bihar is a generational ta-

Today's match

Qualifier 2

 vs. 

New Chandigarh, 7.30 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 10

GT 7 | RR 3

PREVIOUS MEETING

GT won by 77 runs, 2026

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIOHOTSTAR



Crunch time: A lot will hinge on how openers Gill and Sooryavanshi fare for their respective teams in the knockout game. R.V. MOORTHY



We trust our ability and consistency: GT asst. coach Parthiv

Vivek Krishnan
NEW CHANDIGARH

If Gujarat Titans relies on its core of consistent performers to win T20 matches, Rajasthan Royals' hopes seem to ride primarily on the X-factor of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

It is perhaps a simplistic reading of the two franchises, but the neutral observer would certainly gravitate towards the latter simply because of the unadulterated thrill that Sooryavanshi's stroke-making ability elicits.

When a query along these lines was put to Titans' assistant coach Parthiv Patel on the eve of Qualifier 2, the former wicketkeeper-batter asserted that results vindicate the franchise's approach.

"Every team has a different way of playing. We have been quite consistent about the way we go about our business. As long as we are getting results, we don't have to think about whether we need an X-factor," Parthiv said on Thursday.

"Other teams can think whatever they want to think. Even in the first half of the tournament, we



Sai Sudharsan.
SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

were not doing great. But we still stuck to our process. We trust in our ability. If we execute our plans, we can win."

Titans' established template is facilitated by Sai Sudharsan's voracious appetite for run-scoring at the top. He may not be as explosive as the young left-hander in the opposition, but Parthiv sees no need for the opener from Chennai to change tack.

"I don't think there is any kind of temptation to tell Sai Sudharsan to go at a higher strike rate. If someone is striking at 300, it doesn't mean that everyone has to," said Parthiv.

Sooryavanshi's open-and-shut case for India T20I call-up

Vivek Krishnan
NEW CHANDIGARH

India's next T20I assignment is a two-match series against Ireland in Belfast on June 26 and 28.

Following that is a short hop to England for five T20Is from July 1 to 11.

Conventional wisdom may suggest the maintenance of status quo for a team that has just won a T20 World Cup two months ago. But how do you delay Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's entry into the Indian set-up in the shortest format any longer?

Sure, Abhishek Sharma and Sanju Samson have excelled as an opening pair over the past two years. The southpaw from Punjab has been India's best batter in this genre since his debut in 2024. Samson raised his game at the business end of the marquee event, and walked away with the Player-of-the-Tournament award.

"If it ain't broke, don't fix it" may be a sound maxim to heed in usual circumstances, but there is nothing normal about a 15-year-old virtually breaking



Business as usual: Sooryavanshi went on a six-hitting spree against SRH in the Eliminator. R.V. MOORTHY

down the selection door with each passing innings in a sublime IPL campaign. The opener has amassed a chart-topping 680 runs at a strike rate of 242.85.

In the Eliminator against Sunrisers Hyderabad on Wednesday, the ball pinged off his willow with a mellifluous tone during the course of a 29-ball 97. The SRH bowlers planned to bowl full with a straight mid-off and a straight extra-cover for protection, but Sooryavanshi was vigilant in keeping out a couple of Pat Cummins' yorkers before un-

leashing a business-as-usual six-hitting spectacle.

If Sooryavanshi, who will feature for India-A in a 50-over tri-series in Sri Lanka from June 9 to 21, dons the blue shade in Ireland or England, he would be surpassing Sachin Tendulkar's record of being the youngest male cricketer to play for India.

Back in 1989, the selectors didn't shy away from throwing a 16-year-old Tendulkar into the cauldron against Pakistan. The ball is now in the court of the Ajit Agarkar-led selection panel.

Sinner wilts under the heat near the finish line, bows out in second round

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Jannik Sinner's 30-match winning run came to an abrupt halt at the French Open on Thursday as the World No. 1 succumbed to sweltering conditions in a five-set, second-round loss to Juan Manuel Cerundolo.

Sinner, the red-hot favourite at Roland-Garros, appeared to be cruising to victory, holding a two-set lead and a commanding 5-1 advantage in the third, before things took a dramatic turn.

Nobody is a robot

"I had no energy today. That can happen. Nobody is a robot," said the four-time Grand Slam champion, who complained of dehydration and dizziness, saying he felt as though he might vomit.

The Italian left Court Philippe Chatrier to receive medical treatment while serving for the match.

He returned minutes later but Cerundolo sensed his opportunity against an ailing opponent and pre-



Hit by the wave: Sinner tried to cool things down, even employing a hand fan, but the gruelling conditions got to him. REUTERS

ailed 3-6, 2-6, 7-5, 6-1, 6-1.

"I struggled, starting to feel very dizzy," said the 24-year-old Sinner.

"I woke up this morning, didn't feel very well and tried to keep the points very short. In the beginning, I was hitting very clean, very good, and then I just kind of hit the wall."

It was Sinner's earliest exit at a Major since losing at the same stage of the French Open in 2023.

Home hope Moise Kouame became the youngest man to reach the third round of a Grand Slam since Rafael Nadal 23 years ago after an epic win, saying it was a "dream" to win the tournament one day.

THE RESULTS

Second round: Men: Manuel Cerundolo (Arg) bt 1-Sinner (Ita) 3-6, 2-6, 7-5, 6-1, 6-1; 25-Francisco Cerundolo (Arg) bt Gaston (Fra) 2-6, 6-4, 6-2, 6-1; Faria (Por) bt Struff (Ger) 7-5, 7-6(1), 6-2; Tabilo (Chi) w.o. 16-Vacherot (Mon); Kouame (Fra) bt Vallejo (Par) 6-3, 7-5, 3-6, 2-6, 7-6 (10-8); 10-Cobolli (Ita) bt Yibing (Chn) 6-4, 6-4, 6-4; 18-Tien (USA) bt Acosta (Arg) 7-5, 4-6, 3-6, 7-6(4), 6-3; 15-Ruud (Nor) bt Medjedovic (Srb) 6-3, 6-2, 6-4; 24-Paul (USA) bt Sonogo (Ita) 6-3, 6-2, 6-4; 28-Fonseca (Bra) bt Prizmic (Cro) 3-6, 4-6, 6-3, 6-1, 6-2; 2-Zverev (Ger) bt Machac (Cze) 6-4, 6-2, 6-2.

Women: 1-Sabalenka (Blr) bt Jacquemot (Fra) 7-5, 6-2;

17-Jovic (USA) bt Navarro (USA) 6-0, 6-3; 16-Osaka (Jpn) bt Vekic (Cro) 7-6(1), 6-4; 25-Shnaider (Rus) bt Kessler (USA) 7-6(3), 6-1; 19-Keys (USA) bt Ruzic (Cro) 6-4, 6-4; 4-Gauff (USA) bt Sheriff (Egy) 6-3, 6-2; Parry (Fra) bt 30-Li (USA) 6-3, 6-4; 6-Anisimova (USA) bt Grabher (Aut) 6-0, retd.

Mixed doubles: Yuki (Ind) & Panova (Rus) bt Kichenok (Ukr) & Pel (Ned) 7-6(2), 7-6(5).

First round: Men's doubles: Willis (GBr) & Paul (Sui) bt Anirudh (Ind) & Yuzuki (Jpn) 6-3, 6-7(4), 7-6(3).

Fallen seeds: Men: 1-Sinner; 16-Vacherot; **Women:** 23-Mertens, 30-Li.

Friday's Picks	
MEN	
2-Zverev vs. Halys	
3-Djokovic vs. 28-Fonseca	
8-De Minaur vs. 26-Mensik	
11-Rublev vs. Borges	
13-Khachanov vs. De Jong	
WOMEN	
3-Swiatek vs. Linette	
7-Svitolina vs. Korpatsch	
10-Muchova vs. Teichmann	
11-Bencic vs. Stearns	
15-Kostyuk vs. Golubic	

Sport

Double delight for ice-cool Esha in a star-studded field

The 21-year-old guns down gold in women's 25m pistol at the ISSF World Cup in Munich with a World record; the triumph also secures her a berth in the season-ending World Cup Final

SHOOTING
Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Esha Singh's description of shooting makes a challenging discipline seem like child's play. "Our sport is very simple, as is the technique. The only thing that goes wrong is when things crumble under pressure. "The job is to try and not do that and focus on just one or two points," the 21-year-old told The Hindu from Munich after a scintillating World record score of 43/50 to take gold in the women's 25m pistol at the ISSF World Cup. Esha seemingly had ice in her veins as she beat a field that also featured Paris Olympics gold medalist Yang Ji-in and former World champion Doreen Vennekamp.

"I am close friends (with my competitors). I am aware of the big names and what they have achieved. I really can't do anything about it. That said, I also believe I am one of the top athletes. I shoot with that confidence."

Not obsessed
Esha is not one to be obsessed with milestones. She wanted to win the gold and found out about the World record well after sealing her spot on the podium. That it came at Munich,



Significant win: Esha got the better of Olympic gold medalist Yang and former World champion Vennekamp en route her gold. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Munich is a centre point for America and Europe, so everyone can come and compete, and we have almost 100% attendance here. The competitive level is very high

considered one of the tougher pitstops on the World Cup map, made the win sweeter. "Munich is a centre

point for America and Europe, so everyone can come and compete, and we have almost 100% attendance here.

"The competitive level is very high, and even qualifying for the top eight is neck and neck. Just getting to the top eight is an achievement in Munich, I'd say."

Heat factor
She brushed aside the challenging heat that other shooters alluded to. "For an Indian, this is

not hot at all. I was sweating a bit in the finals, but that was more due to pressure and the fact that I am lifting such a heavy gun. We deal with worse conditions in India.

"So normal day," she quipped. The gold medal also brought with it a berth in the season-ending World Cup Final in Rome.

Much like her process, the celebration, too, was a no-fuss affair, a quiet dinner at a regular haunt in the German city.

When you're dishonest to yourself, you are not going to achieve in this world: Kapil

CRICKET
Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Indian cricketing legend Kapil Dev, in a speech peppered with witticisms and worldly wisdom, stressed the importance of being honest to oneself. The World Cup-winning captain was in the city as the chief guest at the launch of the book 'Better Never Stops' written by Shyam Srinivasan, former MD & CEO of The Federal Bank Ltd. "When you write a book or do anything, you have to make sure you are honest to yourself. When you're dishonest to yourself, you are not going to achieve in this world what you are here for," said Kapil.



Blunt talk: Kapil quipped that he took to cricket because it allowed him to be away from class for longer than a game of football. R. RAGU

Recalling his cricketing days, Kapil jokingly quipped that he took to the sport because it allowed him to be away from class



If somebody says, I played for the nation, no, first I played for myself. That is the reality

that gives me the kick. If somebody says, I played for the nation, no, first I played for myself. That is the reality.

Passion
"When I picked up a bat and ball, I never realised that I could play for India. I had a passion as a kid only to play because I was horrible in class. So I started playing cricket. Football meant only one hour of staying away from class, while cricket gave me three days. So I enjoyed that," said Kapil.

AROUND THE CITY

Narendar's five-for wins it for Adambakkam
B. Narendar's five for 21 helped Adambakkam CC beat Spring Field CC by 45 runs in the District Cricket Association of Chengalpattu first division league. The scores: I div: SRM IST 218 in 41.3 overs (Vignesh S. Iyer 33, Ajay Chetan 50, Leela Sai 72) bt Spring Field 138 in 34.4 overs (Aravind Vedhagiri 44, Adittya Varadharajan 4/18, Kumar Ishaan 3/24). Rider 237/9 in 45 overs (Ram Shreyas 109, Joe Krish 46, Aakash 3/24) bt Krish 183 in 35 overs (Kabilan 34, Rahul Kannan 30, Ajay 31, Sachin 3/40). Vijay 275/9 in 45 overs (R. Vivek 72, R. Raj Kumar 108) bt

Syndicate Nanganauallur 266 in 44.2 overs (Dhruv Shiva Sundar 79, S. Gokulahari 41, K. Akshay Kumar 41). Gurunanak Combines 119 in 32 overs (Murali 34, G. Vijay 4/25) lost to Adambakkam 120/1 in 21.1 overs (Prashid Ram 64 n.o.). Gurunanak combines 86 in 17.4 overs (Vignesh S. Iyer 4/3) lost to SRM IST 90/3 in 12.2 overs (Vignesh S. Iyer 31). Adambakkam 148 in 34.5 overs (R. Aashish Kumar 64 n.o., S. Sanjai Srinivasan 4/18) lost to Syndicate Nanganallur 159/8 in 29.3 overs (Aravind 47 n.o., Karthick 35, Ashwin Balaji 3/40). Adambakkam 232/9 in 41.2 overs (S. Gokul 71, A. Aarifi 55, R. Aashish Kumar 50, D. Ram Singh 3/47) bt Rider 121 in 29.5 overs (S. Aneek Kumar 3/12, G. Vijay 4/29).

Sheshadri MCC 219 in 40.3 overs (A. Rahul 44, Lakshmi Narayanan 43, Rishi Rajagopal 34, R. Sabari 45, S. Swaminathan 3/43) lost to Vijay 222/5 in 34.5 overs (S. Arun 54, S. Swaminathan 75, Jagadeesh 53).

Spring Field 158 in 25.1 overs (Balakrishnan 50, Ashwin Balaj 44, Akshay Kumar 3/22, Aravind 3/35, V. Sathyanarayanan 4/18) lost to Syndicate Nanganallur 159/8 in 29.3 overs (Aravind 47 n.o., Karthick 35, Ashwin Balaji 3/40). Adambakkam 232/9 in 41.2 overs (S. Gokul 71, A. Aarifi 55, R. Aashish Kumar 50, D. Ram Singh 3/47) bt Rider 121 in 29.5 overs (S. Aneek Kumar 3/12, G. Vijay 4/29).

Fine Star CA coaching camp
Fine Star CA will conduct

a coaching camp for boys and girls in the 6-19 age group at the Annai Violet College of Arts and Science in Ambattur from June 3. The camp will be held five days a week, from Wednesday to Sunday. Contact 87545 61894 / 99411 98920 or email ahsrikanth26@gmail.com

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: Young Talents u-14 inter-academy Summer Trophy, semifinals, Kabilan Nest turf ground (Medavakkam), 8 a.m. & 1 p.m.; Grand Sports u-18 50-over tournament, Jeppiaar University turf ground (OMR), 8 a.m.

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER
DRM(S&T) NWR, Ajmer on behalf of the President of India invites E-Tender for the following work up to 15.00 Hrs. on the mentioned date. **Tender No.: DRM-S&T-18-2026-27. Name of Work:** Ajmer Division: Provision of Dual VDU by replacing operating panel at 07 Nos. EI stations in (JAL-MOI) section under the jurisdiction of ADSTE/ABR in Ajmer division. Approximate cost of work: Rs. 66498576.74. Bid security: Rs. 1330000.00. Date & Time of opening E-Tender: 22.06.2026 at 15.30 Hrs. The details of above E-Tender are available on website www.ireps.gov.in. 789-MG/26

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE
Sr.DMM/NWR/AJMER acting for and on behalf of the President of India invites E-tenders on www.ireps.gov.in site as follows. All the E-tenders will be closed at 16-MAR-26 14.25 Hrs. **Sr.No. 1. Tender No.:** 52255575B. **Brief Description:** Phaco System Machine. Qty.: 01 set. Unit: Set. Due date: 16/06/2026 at 14.25 Hrs. **Note (1)** Interested tenderers may visit the website www.ireps.gov.in for Full details/description/Specification/EMD & tender cost etc. All tenderers are requested to obtain digital signatures and get them registered on above site and quote electronically only. **(2)** For viewing and participating in other tenders such as open tender costing below Rs. 50 Lakh, limited tenders, special limited tenders and low value tenders, please visit www.ireps.gov.in. 788-MG/26

THE HINDU
Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-;
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
E-Tender Notice
Following E- Tenders are invited by XEN/WS/AIL/NWR-Ajmer at 15.00 Hrs. on the mentioned date. **1. Tender no.:** 02-Workshop-AI-2026-27. **Name of work:** Ajmer-WS-Zone no.-1 (2026-27 & 2027-28)- Repairs & maintenance of building & sanitary work in the area of Loco workshop, Rail Museum, STC School, STC Hostel, Loco ground and Bangalow no 121. **Approximate cost:** Rs.3,35,62,263.04/-. **Earnest money/ Bid Security:** Rs.6,71,300/-. **Tender closing date:** 16.06.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. **2. Tender no.:** 03-Workshop-AI-2026-27. **Name of work:** Ajmer-WS-Zone no.-2(2026-27 & 2027-28)- Repairs & of maintenance building & sanitary work in the area of Carriage workshop, Electric Power House, General Store & Carriage ground. **Approximate cost:** Rs.3,35,62,263.04/-. **Earnest money/ Bid Security:** Rs.6,71,300/-. **Tender closing date:** 16.06.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. The detailed information of the above Tender is available on website www.ireps.gov.in and at the notice board of this office. 777-MG/26

SOUTHERN RAILWAY
Office of the Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer, Carriage Works / Electrical, Perambur, Chennai - 600 023.
E-TENDER NOTICE No. E-E-294-2026-01-A-HT and E-E-294-2026-01-B-HTDUCT
The bidders intending to log on to e-tender for "WORKS TENDERS", need to get enrolled in the e tender website <http://www.ireps.gov.in> and only online tenders will be accepted. The payment towards cost of Bid Security should be made only through online payment modes like net banking, debit/credit cards etc. available on IREPS portal. It is the responsibility of the bidders to obtain necessary Digital Signature Certificates for participating in the e-tender. Complete details and tender document will be available in at <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. For other details, terms and conditions, the tenderers are advised to refer the documents uploaded, All Addendum/Corrigendum, time extension, clarifications etc. will be uploaded in the website only and will not be published separately in Newspapers. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.
Tenderers need not be present in the office for tender opening as they can watch the status of opened tenders, on line IREPS.

Sl. No.	Tender No. & Date	Name of the Work	Approximate Tender Value	Last Date and Time of Submission of e-tender
1	E-E-294-2026-01-A-HT dated: 26-05-2026	Improvement to Power System Reliability in PERAMBUR area by Trenched Laying of HT UG cables.	42,36,234	22-06-2026 at 15:00 hrs.
2	E-E-294-2026-01-B-HTDUCT dated: 26-05-2026	Trenchless HT & LT UG Cable Laying for Power Supply Strengthening in Perambur Area	41,09,379	23-06-2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Period of Completion: SL No. 1 to 2 - 120 Days
Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer, Carriage Works / Electrical Perambur, Chennai - 600 023.

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SOUTHERN RAILWAY
ELECTRICAL BRANCH (GENERAL SERVICES) CHENNAI DIVISION
Tender Notice ME29IISC-Electrowaves2026
The Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer, General Services, Chennai Division, Southern Railway, IVth Floor, NGO Annex, Park Town, Chennai - 600 003 for and on behalf of the President of India invites ONLINE Open Tenders for the E-Tender no. ME29IISC-Electrowaves2026 for the following work as per the Tender Notice issued in our E-Tender portal www.ireps.gov.in. The bidders intending to apply for E-Tender for Works in Chennai Division, need to get enrolled in the aforesaid E-Tender portal and only online tenders will be accepted.

E-TENDER NO	ME29IISC-Electrowaves2026 dt. 25.05.2026
NAME OF THE WORK	Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract for maintenance of out of warranty Electrowaves (M/s. Electrowaves Electronics Pvt. Ltd.) make 25KVA inverters fitted in Roof Mounted AC coaches of Southern Railway for a period of three years
APPROXIMATE COST OF WORK	Rs. 2,70,58,500/- (Rupees Two Crore Seventy Lakh Fifty Eight Thousand and Five Hundred Only.)
EARNEST MONEY DEPOSIT	Rs. 2,85,300/- (Rupees Two Lakh Eighty Five Thousand and Three Hundred only.)
CONTRACT PERIOD	Three Years
TENDER CLOSING DATE AND TIME	15.06.2026 and 16:30 Hrs

1. The details of the approximate cost of Tender value, EMD, and the details of bid submission are furnished in the aforesaid E-Portal.
2. The online bids for tenders floated through the above portal are required to be digitally signed.
3. GST rules applicable from time to time will apply for this E-Tender.
Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer, Chennai Division, Southern Railway, For and On Behalf of the President of India.

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises
INSTITUTE FOR DESIGN OF ELECTRICAL MEASURING INSTRUMENTS, MUMBAI
वैद्युतिक मापन उपकरण अभियन्तव्य संस्थान, मुंबई
Government Certificate Course on **Artificial Intelligence for Chartered Accountants & Tax Practitioners**
Course Duration: 4 Days (ऑनलाइन) Course Date: 6,7,13,14 June 2026
Course Time: 2 PM TO 5.30 PM (ONLINE)
Email ID: training@idemi.org Website: www.idemi.org Ph: [022] 2405 0301/2/3/4
Contents: Data collection, management and methods in accounting integration of data in financial systems with automation and data governance Cleaning of data with visualisation and (EDA (Exploratory data analysis) techniques with descriptive statistics Tax filing using AI and compliance monitoring with automated calculations Real time tax analysis and reporting, AI in tax auditing GST compliance with GST data analysis Prevention of data breaches Data privacy and regulations with tool.
Course Fees-4000+18 % GST (fees are not refundable)
After successful completion certificate will be issued.
For Accountants/Chartered Accountants/Income Tax Practitioners/Chartered Accountants/Chartered Tax Practitioners
29th April 2026 / Call us between 10 am to 6 pm
Contact-8007765693, 9403566219, 9869087617

SOUTHERN RAILWAY
SALEM DIVISION (SIGNAL & TELECOM BRANCH)
E-Tender Notice No. (J)SA-SG-120-10-T-07-2026
Closing date: 18/06/2026.
Senior Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/Southern Railway/Salem Division, Salem - 636005 for and on behalf of the President of India invites ONLINE tenders for the following works as per tender notice given in our e-tender portal www.ireps.gov.in. The tenderer(s)/contractor(s) intending to apply for e-tender for WORKS in Salem Division, need to get enrolled in the e-tender portal www.ireps.gov.in and only online tenders will be accepted. Payment of Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) & Tender Document Cost (TDC), in respect of e-tendering, should be accepted through net banking or payment gateway only. Fixed Deposit Receipt (FDR) will not be accepted as EMD for tenders invited on IREPS (e-tender portal).

Tender Notice No.	SA-SG-120-10-T-07-2026
Name of Work	SALEM DIVISION: Provision of tools and equipments for implementation of SMMs, Painting of S&T assets, Fencing of critical locations and other reliability improvement works over Salem Division.
Approximate Cost of the Work	Rs.2,95,82,012.40
Earnest Money Deposit	Rs.5,91,700.00
Cost of tender form including	Nil
Eligibility criteria for	Applicable
Period of Completion in months	12 Months

Tender closing date and time: 18/06/2026, at 15.00 Hrs.
NOTE: Details of approximate value of tender, tender form cost, EMD & location are given on the e-portal "www.ireps.gov.in".
For other details, terms and conditions, the tenderers are advised to refer to the Tender documents which are available at www.ireps.gov.in website.
Senior Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer, Southern Railway/Salem - 636 005

SOUTHERN RAILWAY
NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER
Chennai Division (Operation Branch)
Custom Bid Number: **GEM/2026/B/7594732** for and on behalf of the President of India, Divisional Railway Manager / Operation Branch, Chennai Division, Southern Railway, V th floor, NGO Annex Building, Park town, Chennai 600 003 invites ON LINE tender from the experienced contractors for the following work as per tender notice given our e- tender portal www.gem.gov.in. Tenderer(s)/Contractor(s) intending to apply for e- tender for Electrical Operation works Chennai Division, need to get enrolled in the e- tender portal www.gem.gov.in, and only online tenders will be accepted.

Description	Outsourcing of maintenance activities, cleaning of Trip Sheds and its surroundings and washing of locomotive bodies and lookout glass at TS/BBQ and MS for two years (730 days)
Approximate cost of work in Rs.	1,47,62,415.28
EMD cost in Rs.	2,23,820.00
Closing date of E-tender (at 10.00 hrs)	18.06.2026
Period of completion.	2 Years (730 days)

The bidders will have to make payments towards Earnest Money Deposit against works tenders through on-line payment modes like net banking, debit/ Credit Card etc. available on E-tender portal. It is the responsibility of the Tenderer(s) / Contractor(s) to obtain necessary Digital Signature Certificate for participating in the E-tender, website particulars: www.gem.gov.in. The details terms and conditions are available in the website.
Divisional eth Railway Manager, (Electrical Operation Branch), Chennai Division, Chennai -3

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Applications are invited from eligible candidates for the following posts.

Sl. No.	Advertisement No.	Name of the Posts	Academic Level	Vacancy
01	PU/R/R6/REG/Advt./02/2026	REGISTRAR	Academic Level	1(one) GT
02	PU/R/R6/COE/Advt./03/2026	CONTROLLER OF EXAMINATIONS	14 with rationalized	1(one) GT
03	PU/R/R6/CDOE/Advt./04/2026	DIRECTOR FOR CDOE	entry Pay : Rs.144200	1(one) GT

Refer our website www.periyaruniversity.ac.in for details. The last date for receipt of the filled – in – applications along with enclosures is 29.06.2026 by 5.15 PM. The University reserves the right to fill up or not to fill up the vacancies notified.

Place: Salem-636 011
Date : 29.05.2026
DIPR/466/DISPLAY/2026
REGISTRAR(FAC)

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH
SAD DEMISE of Rasheed Khan.E. Prop. Super Tele Ads. Passed away on 28.05.2026. Mourned by Family & Friends Ct: 9822115901

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
31st ANNIVERSARY
M.C. CHANDRASEKARAN
Our every minute of living belongs to you !
Son : M.C. Natarajan
Daughter : M.C. Sivakami
Grand Daughters : M.C. Sathheja, S. Nandhini & S. Varshini
Grand Son: M.C.Harshad

FIFTH ANNIVERSARY
V.VENKATESWARA RAO
Retd. RBI Officer
an excellent cricketer,
"In our hearts forever"
Fondly remembered forever by
Vinay, Vrithi, Vidya

20th ANNIVERSARY
BHASKAR SHANKAR
ADVOCATE
1935 - 2006
Son of Bhavani Shankar & Kasivisalakshi
Grand Son of M.T.Rajen
Gratefully Remembered by:
Sukumar- Sunil,
Rashmi, Vishnu & Shiva
Relatives & Friends
98411 84648

5th YEAR ANNIVERSARY
Prof. Dr. A. MANOHARAN
09.02.1938 - 29.05.2021
It's been 5 years since you left us, but we still feel your presence in our hearts. No words can express what it means to remain apart. Bless us and enjoy your stay in heaven. RIP DAD.
Fondly Remembered By:
Mrs.JAYANTHI - SAKTHI SEKARAN, M.Sc., M.SUBDIRAN, M.E., M.SRIDHARAN, M.A., L.L.B., & GRAND CHILDREN



On the ball: PSG captain Marquinhos gears up for the final. REUTERS

Chance for PSG to stake claim to be the best of this era

Associated Press

The Champions League trophy is at stake in the final at Budapest on Saturday. For Paris Saint-Germain and Luis Enrique, it doesn't end there.

On the line against Arsenal for the defending champion and its serial-winning Spanish coach is the chance to stake its claim to be considered the greatest team of this era.

"I arrived at the club thinking, 'My objective is to make history,' and we have indeed made history," Enrique said.

"We want to keep writing the story because we believe there's still more there for us to achieve."

PSG is already in the conversation when it comes to judging the finest teams to have won the title in the age of the Champions League.

Victory at Puskas Arena would see PSG become only the second team to retain the trophy since the old European Cup was rebranded as the Champions League in 1992.

For many years it didn't happen even for teams regarded as generationally

great. Pep Guardiola's Barcelona won two in three years.

AC Milan and Juventus each reached three consecutive finals in the '90s but only won one apiece.

Ajax and Manchester United took title defences all the way to the final only to fall at the last hurdle.

Real Madrid – winner of more European titles than any other club – finally bucked that trend, winning three in a row from 2016-18. What seemed unthinkable before and since would suddenly seem a very real target for PSG if it prevails in the final.

Enrique would join Guardiola and Zinedine Zidane as a three-time Champions League winner.

Having won the Champions League with Barcelona, Enrique has produced a PSG team that has set the benchmark in Europe over the past two seasons.

It combines attacking flair with an energy and tenacity that appears to be moving the sport in a new direction.

A team that plays with a high risk of being exposed defensively for the ultimate reward.

PSG, Arsenal would go all out in quest for European glory, says Westwood

The Englishman believes pressure will be less on both sides since they have won domestic league titles; Blasters' interim coach feels the upcoming World Cup would have no effect on the contest



Who will have the last laugh? Enrique is looking to land a second successive Champions League trophy for PSG while Arteta is on the verge of winning a maiden title for the Gunners in Europe's elite club competition. AFP

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Sankar Narayanan E.H.

Luis Enrique vs. Mikel Arteta; Paris vs. London; Ligue 1 title-holder vs. Premier League winner; Paris Saint-Germain vs. Arsenal.

The battle for continental supremacy is around the corner, and these two European giants are the last pair standing in the quest for the UEFA Champions League crown.

Ashley Westwood, who turned Kerala Blasters' ISL campaign north as interim head coach, believes Saturday's final "will be a bonus game" for both domestic champions.

"They've got nothing to lose as they've had the for-



Westwood.
FILE PHOTO: THULASI KAKKAT

ture of winning their leagues. That has released the shackles. It's a bonus game after the season," Westwood told *The Hindu* during a virtual interaction on Thursday.

"There's no pressure (unlike when) you've lost the league and have to win

the Champions League to ensure you've had a successful season. The league's the hardest thing to win as it's across a lot more games."

The Englishman believes Arsenal should stick with its compact set-up against PSG.

"The more expansive Arsenal tries to be, the more dangerous PSG would become. If anything, Arsenal may be even more defensive."

"They're not going to sit right back on the edge of the box. But they will defend in sevens and eights. They won't push a high press, and will stay nice and pragmatic."

On the Gunners' propensity to convert from free-kicks, Westwood added: "Arsenal does have a

great success rate on set-pieces. But to get set-pieces, you have to attack. There's no point defending for 90 minutes because the ball won't enter the opposition's penalty area. And you may not be able to get your set-pieces. So, Arsenal will still try to impose themselves."

Will the upcoming FIFA World Cup cause players to hold back? Not a chance, says Westwood.

"Being in a Champions League final is rare. You have a better chance of winning a European Cup final than a World Cup final".

(Watch the UEFA Champions League final between PSG and Arsenal on Saturday from 9.30 p.m. IST live on Sony Sports Ten 2 SD & HD and Sony LIV).

Arteta and Co. hope to script 'new history'

Reuters
LONDON

Seven years after returning to a fractured Arsenal, manager Mikel Arteta, who will lead his side into Saturday's Champions League final against Paris St Germain in Budapest, is one win away from completing a remarkable rebuild.

Guiding Arsenal to its first Premier League title since 2004 has already repaid the club's long-term faith in him. Now, the Spaniard has the opportunity to go one step further and cap what could be the greatest season in Arsenal's history by delivering Europe's biggest club prize for the first time.

For a coach shaped by Pep Guardiola during a three-year spell as Manchester City assistant, imitation might have been the obvious route. Many have tried – and failed – to reproduce Guardiola's blueprint. Arteta chose a different path. Arsenal's rise has been built not only on control but also on pragmatism.

A side once mocked for vulnerability has been reshaped into one adept at winning 'ugly' when necessary. "You have to be ruthless and you have to be consistent... to create a

winning mentality," Arteta had said after arriving at Arsenal in 2019. "Without an identity, you cannot plan and convince a player to do what you want."

The reset went beyond tactics. Arteta changed the environment at the training ground at London Colney, surrounding players with messages, mantras and symbols. Unity and accountability became daily expectations, while team bonding helped create a tightly-connected group.

Attention to detail has translated directly onto the pitch. The appointment of set-piece coach Nicolas Jover in 2021 proved a turning point, converting marginal gains into a decisive weapon. Arsenal has broken the Premier League record for goals from corners this season, with more than a third of the goals coming from set-pieces.

A string of narrow wins underlined its evolution from nearly-men to champion. Arteta points to the collective. "It is just a joy of a group... the togetherness, the unity, the love, the respect," he had said.

Now, that belief faces its ultimate test against PSG. "We have an amazing opportunity to write new history in our football club," Arteta said.



Next goal: Having ended its long wait for a Premier League title, Arsenal is now targeting a double. AP





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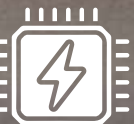
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A CH-CH

Of not-so-nervous nineties

The numbers seem to have veered away from traditional parameters such as fifties, hundreds and averages, especially when it comes to limited-overs cricket and particularly the shortest format



On the charge: While Patidar has passed the litmus second-season test, ramping up the aggression by several notches, Sooryavanshi has been the biggest draw of the league’s 19th edition. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP & R.V. MOORTHY

R. Kaushik

The single is cricket’s most humble gift for a batter; it can also be most humbling. Let’s never underestimate the power of the single.

The difference between 100 and 99 is just one run, but try telling that to a batter who has just been dismissed, tantalisingly close to the three-figure mark. Ninety-nine might be romanticised for the one run that got away but every batter worth his salt would rather take the pragmatic (the hundred, of course) over the romantic.

The difference between 1 and zero is also just one run. No matter how many runs one might have scored in the past, to get off the dreaded nought is the first objective of any batter, at any level. There is a sense of relief at having avoided the duck that can’t be quantified in words, though everyone who has ever held a bat will readily relate to what we are seeking to say.

When the modest single can hold such tremendous significance, where do we place the 90s? Once the ‘nervous nineties’ but no longer so, it would seem, because cricketing goalposts have shifted. Even though the sport will continue to be driven and dictated by numbers, those numbers seen to have veered away from traditional parameters such as fifties and hundreds and averages, especially when it comes to limited-overs cricket and particularly to the T20 format where efficacy is decided less by averages and more by strike-rates.

There have been two extraordinary 90s on the first two playoff nights of IPL 2026, both in winning causes, both produced at breakneck pace, both knocking the stuffing out of the opposition. Delivered by exceptionally popular individuals.

Rajat Patidar unleashed the first of those essays, in the mountains of Dharamsala in Tuesday’s Qualifier 1. Last year, Patidar emerged as a surprise choice to succeed Faf du Plessis as Royal Challengers Bengaluru’s captain. The man from Indore didn’t have a great deal of captaincy experience at the senior level but the management group at the Bengaluru franchise was convinced he had the leadership and man-management skills required to drive the side to a much-awaited maiden crown.

Patidar took perhaps even himself by surprise by doing precisely that. Fears that he would be a captain only in name and that the strings would be pulled by other quarters proved singularly unfounded. Patidar showed that aggression need not manifest itself only through body language and antics. He also revealed the steel the RCB management had identified in him, running a tight ship and making sure that

Sooryavanshi is a source that keeps giving. Giving entertainment, sure, but also joy and exhilaration. His free spirit is infectious

the cares of captaincy didn’t affect his batting too adversely. His numbers weren’t spectacular – 312 runs in 14 innings, strike-rate 143.77 – but they were more than passable, though even if he had made a million runs, they would have been eclipsed by the incandescent afterglow triggered by the end of a seemingly endless wait.

Greater scrutiny

In all sport, there is greater scrutiny on the second season – the second season as a player, as a team, as a leader in this instance. Patidar has comprehensively passed the litmus second-season test, ramping up the aggression in his batting by several notches, becoming more expressive and independent as a leader and muscling his team to a second successive final.

Unlike last year when he rode piggyback on Virat Kohli and Phil Salt’s exploits at the top of the order and from weighty middle-order contributions from Devdutt Padikkal, Jitesh Sharma and the powerful Tim David, Patidar has been at the vanguard of Bengaluru’s vaunted ‘Play Bold’ philosophy. Only Kohli (600) has more runs for the team than Patidar, whose 486 runs have come at a frenetic strike-rate of 196.76. He has smacked 41 sixes, only behind teen phenom Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and Abhishek Sharma (43). All other things being equal, Patidar should go past Abhishek in Sunday’s final though he won’t go anywhere near runaway train Sooryavanshi, who has an incredible 65 sixes to his name.

The 90 – 93 not out, to be precise – we referred to earlier in the piece came in Qualifier 1, against Gujarat Titans who, inarguably, possess the most potent bowling attack of the competition. It was on the back of this attack – Kagiso Rabada, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Jason Holder and Rashid Khan, wow – that Shubman Gill hoped to make inroads into the powerful Bengaluru batting, but his plans were dashed by Kohli and Padikkal, who added 72 for the second wicket in just 38 deliveries.

Patidar strode in when Kohli chopped Holder on to his stumps, 93 for 2 after 8.2 overs; two deliveries later, he saw Padikkal disappear, caught behind. At 94 for 3, Bengaluru were in a spot, Gujarat threatening to push back, when Patidar counter-attacked with a ferocity that rocked the 2022 champions. Patidar has the not-unfounded reputation of being a slayer of spin which he lived up to, but by his own admission, he relishes pace on

the ball. He took and destroyed the Gujarat fast bowlers, sparing no one and no part of the ground; the most stunning of his nine sixes was a backfoot drive off Rabada that screamed over wide long-off for the most glorious spectacle of a night full of glorious spectacles.

When the final ball was bowled, Patidar was at the non-striker’s end, spent but exhilarated, having pummelled 93 from just 33 deliveries. With two balls left in the last over from Prasidh, he was on 92 and on target for a second IPL century but that didn’t eventuate. Never mind. This 93* was every bit worth a hundred, catapulting his side to 254 for five, a commanding 92 runs beyond Gujarat’s reach.

Twenty-four hours later, in the first of the designated knockout games of the tournament, a young boy with the world at his feet unleashed such mayhem that even Patidar’s furious knock appeared pedestrian by comparison. Okay, so we exaggerate. Not pedestrian – how can a strike-rate of 281.81 be classed so? – but definitely second fiddle because the said protagonist, the 15-year-old boy-child, scored at 334.48. He smashed sixes for fun, he intimidated and terrorised men twice his age and with ten times his experience, and he did so with a nonchalance that took one’s breath away.

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi left Sunrisers Hyderabad shell-shocked in Wednesday’s Eliminator at New Chandigarh. He shouldn’t have, really, because he had already offered enough evidence of the carnage he can unleash. Twice in the preceding 14 games, he had smacked 15-ball half-centuries; he boasted 53 sixes, each one a thing of beauty and a joy forever. He had dismantled Jasprit Bumrah and Josh Hazlewood, Rabada and Rashid. He hadn’t let any bowler go unpunished, there didn’t seem an Achilles’ heel though some believed bowling really full – yorker-length – could check his rampage.

The problem with that ploy is that if one is even slightly off the mark, punishment is instantaneous and brutal. As Pat Cummins found out in the very first over. The Australian skipper seemed to have gotten out of the first over unscathed when his last ball landed just a few inches short of a yorker. Sooryavanshi immediately pounced on it, slamming it over the bowler’s head and into the sightsscreen for the first of what would turn out to be a dozen sixes.

He should not be doing this, you know? He should be sitting in the stands, or at home with his parents watching the ball on TV. He isn’t even of legal driving age, yet here he is, with a rapier for a bat, driving the best in the world ragged, driving the fans in the stands into delirium. He does so with nary an expression, almost as if he is oblivious to the fuss around him, as if he is unaware of

the special gift that has been bestowed upon him. He does 15-year-old things, but also with a maturity way beyond someone of his age. With panache and style, but also with a certain humility that is a reflection of his upbringing as well as the access to the wisdom he has already had in his short career in the form of coaches such as Rahul Dravid (at Rajasthan Royals) and V.V.S. Laxman (at India Under-19).

There was a sense of deja vu as Sooryavanshi lay into the Hyderabad bowling on Wednesday night. One felt one had seen all this before – which we all have, of course – but one also wanted more. Much more.

To expect so much from someone so young is beyond unfair but remarkably, magically, miraculously, Sooryavanshi is a source that keeps giving. Giving entertainment, sure, but also joy and exhilaration. His free spirit is infectious and if you find yourself smiling at several of the audacious strokes cascading off his willow, rest assured that you are not alone in doing so.

Breathtakingly irreverent

His onslaught on Cummins in the third over was breathtakingly irreverent. Here was one of the greatest fast bowlers of all time, reduced to bowling in hope more than conviction, aware that anything less than the most perfect execution would come at a massive cost. To bowl with that much pressure can make even the most seasoned blanch. Cummins must have experienced a humbling feeling on which he can share notes with other virtuosos, including his compatriots Hazlewood and Mitchell Starc.

As Sooryavanshi went through the gears and breezed past landmarks, thousands at the ground and millions sitting in their living rooms, in clubs and pubs and bars, egged him on. We were firmly in his corner as he waltzed past Gayle’s 59 sixes, we cheered as he catapulted into the 90s. When he reached 97 off 28, we knew he was one boundary away from upending the Jamaican legend as the maker of the fastest IPL hundred. Gayle had taken 30 deliveries, in 2012; how fitting it would have been had Sooryavanshi got there in 29 because hey, is there a more natural successor?

In the end, it wasn’t to be. Sooryavanshi was caught at third man to collective groans; he took an eternity to drag him off the park, not just because he had missed out on a hundred but because he didn’t help the team’s cause more. As if. “My hundreds will come,” he would say later, sagely, with a 15-year-old’s dazzling smile, “but I was more intent on contributing more for my side.” Like GR Vishwanath’s unbeaten knock of the same numerical magnitude against West Indies in the Chennai Test of 1975, this was a 97 that trumped a hundred. Effortlessly.

THE GIST

There have been two extraordinary 90s on the first two playoff nights of IPL 2026, both in winning causes, both produced at breakneck pace, both knocking the stuffing out of the opposition

Patidar has been at the vanguard of Bengaluru’s vaunted ‘Play Bold’ philosophy. Patidar has the not-unfounded reputation of being a slayer of spin which he lived up to, but by his own admission, he relishes pace on the ball

Sooryavanshi missed out on the fastest IPL hundred by a whisker. He was caught at third man to collective groans; the southpaw took an eternity to drag him off the park, not just because he had fallen on the verge of a record but because he didn’t help the team’s cause more

HEALTH

One pair of feet: women, work and tuberculosis in Mumbai

Women TB patients living on the margins struggle to access healthcare; those living in low and middle-income countries routinely dissolve savings, borrow money, or sell assets to cope with treatment costs while research finds that lower social class is associated with higher waiting times at health facilities

Nidhi Kadere

Divya wakes up at 4 a.m. Her husband leaves for the garment factory in Kurla before the sun is up, and food must be ready before he goes. After cooking comes dusting, wiping, filling and storing water, and the shower. By 6.30 a.m., her two children are awake, the youngest needs bathing, tiffins need packing, and by the time she sends them to school the clock strikes 7.30.

Divya has barely sat down in peace since she started tuberculosis treatment at Shatabdi Hospital. A resident of Govandi, she first suspected something was wrong four months before she received a diagnosis. She had been treated for TB once before, in 2010, and when the lumps reappeared on the back of her neck she told her doctor. He said it was dandruff. When the pain became unbearable, a second doctor gave her something for the pain, and that did not work either. “I finally went to a female doctor in my area,” she says, “and she diagnosed me with TB.”

She took the medications for two months but something still did not feel right, and when she finally went to Shatabdi Hospital and was properly tested, she had developed multidrug-resistant TB.

Incorrect treatment – wrong drugs, improper doses, single medications instead of combination therapy can turn standard curable TB into MDR-TB. The India TB Report 2023 notes that women experience diagnostic delays of up to two to three months due to fears of stigma, and that 40% of female TB patients in an ICMR study reported facing discrimination, including job loss or family rejection.

A study drawing on 80 qualitative interviews with poor women working in informal arrangements at DOTS centres in Bengaluru found that TB symptoms were routinely normalised as workplace health problems, and misread by medical personnel as work-related conditions, confounding early accurate diagnosis.

“There were many days when I would faint while something was cooking on the stove and the whole house would turn black with smoke. My neighbours had to break the door to come in and check. The drugs were so strong that my teeth would fall into the food while I was eating,” Divya says. She eventually took up a job as a school bus attendant to save for dental implants. India’s free TB programme does not account for out-of-pocket expenses incurred during months and years of treatment.

Losing a workday

Three kilometres away in Mankhurd, Rehana Shaikh is already on the bus. She left home at 6.30 a.m. and is a domestic worker covering two households in Chembur, paid by the day. She has pulmonary TB, drug-sensitive, and is being treated at the DOTS centre at Shatabdi Hospital. Standard drug-sensitive TB takes six months to treat, and under Directly Observed Treatment Shortcourse Therapy, patients visit a clinic three to five times a week during the initial phase, amounting to over 40 to 70 total visits. “The clinics open at 10 a.m., so I have to take a half day to collect my medicines three times a



Nursing college students taking out an awareness rally on the occasion of World Tuberculosis Day. A study found that TB symptoms were routinely normalised as workplace health problems, and misread by medical personnel as work-related conditions, confounding early accurate diagnosis. K.V.S. GIRI

week. I cannot do it after work since the clinic closes at 5 p.m., sometimes 4 p.m. I can’t choose between illness and losing my salary,” Rehana says.

The TB medication makes her dizzy, a low constant unsteadiness she manages by keeping still and not carrying too much weight. She arrives at the clinic by 9.45 a.m. By the time the clinic opens, they tell her they are short on medicines. She takes the bus back and reaches her employer in Chembur by noon, having lost the morning. In a job paid by attendance, losing the morning means losing the wages, and this happens twice a week.

India’s National Time Use Survey 2024, a government survey of 4.54 lakh individuals published by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation in February 2025, tells us that women spend 305 minutes every day on unpaid domestic work compared to men’s 88. Four out of 10 women aged 15 to 59 are their household’s primary caregiver, spending 140 minutes daily on that work against 74 minutes for men.

The medication makes her weaker over the weeks. Due to the weakness, Rehana has to take more breaks and gets late for work. This in turn affects her income, which is already below minimum wage, shrinking further with each half day she takes.

A 2024 study in *PLOS Global Public Health* following 1,482 TB patients across four States including Maharashtra found that between 30 and 61% faced catastrophic costs, defined as treatment expenses exceeding 20% of annual household income, and that for more than half, those costs began before a single dose of treatment was taken. Another cost analysis found that indirect costs, lost wages, lost time and lost productivity, constitute 93.4% of what TB actually costs an Indian patient. The medicine is the smallest part of the bill. Rehana returns home at 7 p.m., cooks, and sleeps by 11. The next morning, she has to go for a test again.

The road from Kanjurmarg to Sewri TB Hospital takes Amita through the spine of the city. A home-maker in her late thirties living in a one-room tenement, she has extrapulmonary TB, a type that affects the lymph nodes, which do not appear on a standard chest X-ray and are harder to diagnose and easier to dismiss. Her treatment is at Sewri TB Hospital, Mumbai’s oldest dedicated TB facility, treating the city’s poor since 1941. The commute is over an hour and a half each way on a good day – Central Railway from Kanjurmarg to Kurla, a change to the Harbour Line, Sewri station, and then a 15-minute walk or a bus to the hospital gate. She has no income of her own, and the decision of when she goes, how often, and whether she can afford the fare to and from the clinic this week is not entirely hers to make.

India’s National Family Health Survey 5, conducted between 2019 and 2021 across more than 6,00,000 households, found that nationally 21.5% of women said transport was a problem in accessing medical care, 23.2% cited distance, and overall 60% reported at least one barrier to healthcare. In Maharashtra, an analysis of the survey found that 56% of women identified transport as a major barrier to accessing care.

For Amita, the barrier is not just the bus. It is the permission to take it.

Waiting for care

A woman in an affluent neighbourhood in Bandra with the same disease and the same drug protocol has health insurance, paid leave, a private pulmonologist who sees her within minutes, and a household income that does not collapse when she misses a morning of work. TB patients in low and middle-income countries routinely dissolve savings, borrow money, or sell assets to cope with treatment costs. For Rehana, whose income is already below minimum wage, there are no savings to dissolve and no assets to sell.

Govandi and Mankhurd are home to large concentrations of Dalit and OBC

households, communities pushed to the city’s edges by decades of displacement and urban planning that never considered them its intended beneficiaries. Research using data from 27,251 Indian households found that lower social class is associated with higher waiting times at health facilities, and that caste-related inequality in waiting time has worsened over time. Residents of these settlements rely almost entirely on public transport to access healthcare, and the eastern suburbs record the lowest accessibility scores for government healthcare facilities in the entire city. They have the highest TB burdens and the highest concentration of informal women workers.

The sociologist Javier Auyero argued in *Patients of the State* that waiting is not a passive exercise for all; it is how the state exercises power over people who cannot afford to pay to bypass it. Low-income communities in India routinely wait for employment, basic services and subsidised goods, delays that expose an unequal distribution of resources and power. Women are more likely than men to work part-time, earn less, and remain outside health insurance or retirement protections. Their time is the invisible part of the iceberg on which the city’s economy stands.

The Nikshay Poshan Yojana provides a direct benefit transfer of ₹1,000 per month to registered TB patients for the duration of treatment. A move that can help women barely make up for the lost wages and out-of-pocket expenses.

A Chennai study found that when DOTS clinics offered evening hours, treatment completion rates among working patients rose to near-universal, with almost one-fifth of patients previously missing treatment because of their work schedule.

Yet Mumbai’s DOTS centres operate from 10 a.m. to 5 p.m., and evening hours have not been systematically introduced. (Nidhi Kadere is a freelance journalist who writes on health, gender and governance nidhiwritinglife2@gmail.com)

THE GIST

The India TB Report 2023 notes that women experience diagnostic delays of up to two to three months due to fears of stigma, and that 40% of female TB patients in an ICMR study reported facing discrimination, including job loss or family rejection. Incorrect treatment – wrong drugs, improper doses, single medications instead of combination therapy can turn standard curable TB into MDR-TB.

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Colour blindness: a hidden vision condition many don’t realise they have

Lakshmi S.

Despite being prevalent among Indians, knowledge and understanding of colour blindness in India is extremely poor. Most of the general population believes that colour blindness is when one sees the world only in shades of black and white. But this is not the case: most people with colour blindness cannot discriminate only between certain colours, namely red-green or blue-yellow combinations. The disorder is congenital and thus, many people may be unaware of their condition all their lives.

Indian scenario

According to various studies in India, around 8% of men and 0.5% of women suffer from colour blindness, which means almost 70 million Indians are potentially colour blind. Red-green type of this vision

problem is the most common type of colour blindness, caused by a gene mutation located on the X chromosome. Thus, since men have just one X chromosome, they are much more susceptible to inheriting this condition from their parents compared to women.

A serious problem with colour-blindness is that this condition influences one’s life unnoticed. Common problems that people with this condition might face on daily basis range from the serious to the minor: misinterpreting traffic lights, a negative impact on academic performance of students, an inability to match clothes, problems working with colour-coded charts or maps, issues with choosing ripe fruit, and problems with interpreting colour signals. Many of these issues can go unnoticed until the person gets diagnosed with the problem.

It should be noted that there are



Colour clarity: According to various studies in India, around 8% of men and 0.5% of women suffer from colour blindness. GETTY IMAGES

multiple types of colour blindness. For example, red-green is the most common type, while blue-yellow type and complete colour blindness

are rather uncommon. Besides, while this problem is usually genetic, it can also develop due to diabetes mellitus, glaucoma, cataracts, retinal

diseases, optic nerve disease, brain injury, with ageing and certain medicines.

Any changes in colour vision should be checked by an ophthalmologist, as it can mean an underlying serious eye or neurological condition.

Testing of colour vision is necessary for children and adults who have diabetes or any chronic eye diseases. Unfortunately, colour blindness awareness is not high enough in India to allow for testing in schools for every child.

Addressing myths

There are also certain myths that should be addressed. First of all, it is a misconception that colour blindness leads to total blindness. It also has no connection to intelligence. Despite the fact that there are no ways to treat genetically-determined colour blindness permanently, some

individuals can be helped by colour-filter glasses, which allow for discriminating between different colours. However, there is no permanent cure for colour blindness.

More awareness

Schools, workplaces, and other areas use colour codes extensively, making the creation of colourblind-friendly environments necessary. Teachers and other educators need to be aware that students should not be punished for colour blindness.

Accommodating this need in individuals may involve the use of labels instead of colours, adding patterns or symbols, improving lighting, and using certain apps that can help identify colours. (Dr. Lakshmi S. is head, clinical services, Dr. Agarwals Eye Hospital, Chennai. omprakash.lakshmi@yahoo.com)

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of people killed in Israeli strikes on Lebanon

14 Lebanon's Health Ministry said on Thursday that Israeli strikes on the country's south killed at least 14 people and wounded 21 others. The Lebanese military added that a soldier had been killed in a separate Israeli strike "while he was driving on the road". AFP

Highway assets identified by NHAI for monetisation in FY27

17 State-owned NHAI on Thursday said it has identified 17 National Highways assets with a total combined length of 1,692.5 km for monetisation under toll-operate-transfer and infrastructure investment trust modes during the financial year 2026–27. PTI

France's prison population reaches record high

88,145 UN experts on torture prevention urged France to fix "serious" overcrowding in prisons, saying the conditions violated detainees' rights and could be labelled "inhumane or degrading" treatment. AFP

Children killed in a fire in a school dorm in Kenya

16 A fire in a girls' dormitory in Kenya on Thursday killed 16 children and hospitalised 79. The fire broke out before 1:00 am local time at Utumishi Girls Academy in Nakuru County, around 120 kilometres north of the capital Nairobi, officials said. AFP

Increase in China's gold imports via Hong Kong in April

81.2 in per cent. China's net gold imports via Hong Kong rose 81.2% in April from the previous month, Hong Kong Census and Statistics Department data showed on Thursday. PTI
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A revival of sedition tied to consent

The Supreme Court's May 21 clarification partially revives sedition proceedings under Section 124A for consenting accused persons; the direction creates disparity in the working of Section 124A and leaves accused caught between trial under an undecided law and indefinite limbo

LETTER & SPIRIT

Krishnadas Rajagopal

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant clarified on May 21 that courts may proceed with trials, appeals and proceedings under Section 124A of the now-repealed Indian Penal Code if the accused raise no objection. In effect, the direction partially revived the paused colonial-era sedition provision for those willing to face trial.

The direction came in a special leave petition filed by a person anxious about his nearly-decade-old appeal against conviction under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, the Arms Act, and several provisions of the IPC, including Section 124A.

He and his co-accused were sentenced to life imprisonment by a Sessions Court in Madhya Pradesh in February 2017. Their appeal before the State High Court had remained in limbo after the Supreme Court ordered all ongoing and future proceedings under Section 124A to be kept in abeyance in an interim order on May 11, 2022.

The Supreme Court Bench found that the High Court "appeared reluctant" to hear the appeal while the May 2022 order remained in force. The appellant in this case, Kamran, submitted that he was willing to let the High Court hear the appeal in its entirety, including with respect to sedition.

The Bench relented by passing a general direction that sedition proceedings under Section 124A against consenting accused persons, like Kamran, should go ahead. The court's decision, apparently, was guided by speedy trial and closure for the accused and reducing the burden on the justice administration system, already groaning under a backlog.

Constitutional questions

However, on the flip side, the Supreme Court's clarification has exposed consenting accused persons to be subject to a provision which both the court and the government had considered suspect in 2022. The challenge to the



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constitutionality of Section 124A is pending in the Supreme Court. Multiple writ petitions in *S.G. Vombatkere versus Union of India* had challenged Section 124A for violating foundational rights.

The pendency of the Vombatkere petitions raises the question whether lower courts would pronounce a judgment on guilt when the constitutionality of the provision was itself suspect. Besides, the May 21 clarification was passed in an unconnected case, *Kamran versus State of Madhya Pradesh*, without issuing notice to or hearing the petitioners in the Vombatkere group of matters.

Practical problems may also arise for lower courts if one accused is willing to be tried under Section 124A while his co-accused may not. The answer lies in deciding the petitions challenging the colonial provision, and not delivering stopgap clarifications.

The clarification of May 21 further rebels against the fundamental right of 'equality before the law'. The interim order of May 2022 had expressed the Supreme Court's "hope and expectation" that the government would not register any fresh FIRs, continue investigation or take coercive measures against people under Section 124A while the challenge to the provision was still alive in the apex court. The order had given affected

parties, against whom Section 124A was invoked, liberty to approach courts for relief. It had gone to the extent of directing that adjudication with respect to connected Sections in such cases would proceed only if courts were of the opinion that no prejudice would be caused to the accused. None of these directions was modified on May 21.

Unequal consequences

The clarification may lead to a visible disparity in the working of Section 124A. Trials and court proceedings would resume against the accused who may have consented out of a sense of anguish or were sure of their innocence, while others, not so frantic for closure, would opt to quietly wait it out till the apex court finally decided on the legality of Section 124A. The Supreme Court's prolonged delay on the Vombatkere petitions leaves vulnerable citizens stranded between a rock and a hard place: either consent to a trial under an undecided law, which carries a life imprisonment, or endure indefinite limbo.

Again, the May 21 direction would mean trial and appeals would resume for consenting accused on a provision which the apex court and the Centre had agreed in 2022 was not in tune with the current social milieu, and was intended for a time when this country was under the colonial

regime. The Attorney General had, at the time, shared instances of glaring misuse of Section 124A, like when an independent MP and her husband were booked under Section 124A after they threatened to recite the *Hanuman Chalisa* outside the private residence of a former Maharashtra Chief Minister.

The offence of sedition has been traced to the Statute of Westminster 1275, when the King was considered the holder of the Divine right. Pre-dating the Constitution, the provision has been viewed with suspicion in Independent India. The country's first Prime Minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, had described the Section on the floor of the Provisional Parliament in 1951 as "highly objectionable and obnoxious". In 1962, the Supreme Court in *Kedar Nath Singh versus State of Bihar* read it down to say that a "citizen has a right to say or write whatever he likes about the government, or its measures, by way of criticism or comment, so long as he does not incite people to violence or with an intention of creating public disorder".

Burden on State

Even Section 152 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, considered a successor to Section 124A, is under challenge in the Supreme Court for its ambiguity, cloaking an immense capacity to have a chilling effect on free speech and expression.

The current challenges to sedition provisions urge the Supreme Court to conform to post-Kedar Nath precedents like *R.C. Cooper, Indira Gandhi versus Raj Narain* and *I.R. Coelho*, which established that fundamental rights did not reside in isolated silos or watertight compartments – a curtailment of free speech brought about by a charge under Section 124A or Section 152 would also affect the right to life and personal liberty. The content of each fundamental right animates the others.

The burden is on the State to establish that a "rights-limiting" sedition provision is necessary in a democratic society. It should not be left to affected parties to consent to sedition proceedings out of sheer desperation caused by a delay to decide the constitutionality of Section 124A by none other than the highest court of the country.

THE GIST

The May 21 clarification allows trials, appeals and proceedings under Section 124A to go ahead for accused persons willing to face trial, even as the challenge to the constitutionality of the provision remains pending in the Supreme Court.

The prolonged delay in deciding the Vombatkere petitions leaves vulnerable citizens between consenting to proceedings under a colonial-era law carrying life imprisonment or remaining in prolonged limbo.

What did the court rule on Bihar's SIR of electoral rolls?

What were the four main issues raised by the petitioners against the SIR exercise?

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

The Supreme Court recently upheld the powers of the Election Commission (EC) to conduct special intensive revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls in Bihar. It also upheld the procedure followed by the EC.

What was SIR?

Article 324 of the Constitution provides that the superintendence, direction and control of the preparation of electoral rolls for the conduct of elections shall vest with the EC. Section 21 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950 (RP Act), deals with the preparation and revision of electoral rolls. It authorises the EC to carry out a special revision of the electoral roll, for any constituency at any

time, for reasons to be recorded.

In its June 2025 order to carry out the SIR of Bihar electoral rolls, the EC noted that there had been large-scale additions and deletions to the electoral rolls over the last 20 years due to rapid urbanisation and migration. This has increased the possibility of duplicate entries in the electoral roll. The EC stated that it is also constitutionally obligated to ensure that only citizens are enrolled in the electoral rolls. Accordingly, the EC decided to undertake an SIR exercise for the entire country, starting with Bihar.

What issues were raised?

The Association for Democratic Reforms and various other petitioners had challenged the SIR exercise in the Supreme Court. The key issues for consideration in these petitions are summarised below.

First, whether the EC is empowered to carry out the SIR exercise. Section 21(3) of the RP Act authorises the EC to carry out a special revision of the electoral roll for 'any' constituency or part of a constituency in such manner as it may think fit. The petitioners argued that this provision is for special revision of only a particular constituency and not for a State as a whole, as envisaged in the SIR process.

Second, if the SIR is founded on a legitimate purpose, whether the measures adopted by the EC are proportionate to the object being sought to be achieved. Third, whether the procedure is violative of provisions of the RP Act and Registration of Electors Rules, 1960 (RER). The petitioners argued that enrolment in the electoral roll carries a presumption of citizenship and eligibility. Rule 21A of the RER mandates that no

name already entered in the electoral roll can be deleted without prior notice to the elector concerned and an opportunity of hearing. The petitioners argued that requiring all electors to fill out the enumeration forms again and deleting the names of those who fail to submit them violates these provisions. Fourth, whether the EC is empowered to scrutinise the citizenship status of persons seeking inclusion or continuation in the electoral roll.

What did the court rule?

The court, after hearing the petitioners and EC, upheld the SIR exercise and procedure followed. The conclusion of the court for the four main issues raised can be summarised as follows. First, the interpretation of the word 'any' in Section 21(3) of the RP Act as 'only' for a particular constituency would be narrow and restrictive. The EC is well within its constitutional mandate to carry out SIR for 'many' or 'all' constituencies in a State. It is an exercise traceable to Section 21(3) read with Article 324 of the Constitution to fulfil the constitutional requirement of free and fair elections.

Second, the SIR exercise satisfies the proportionality requirement. The measures adopted bear a rational nexus to the objective sought to be achieved, are not manifestly excessive, and are accompanied by sufficient procedural

safeguards to prevent arbitrary exclusion.

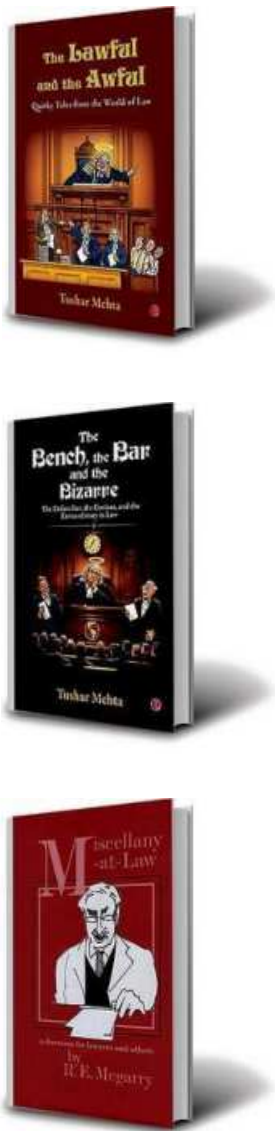
Third, while inclusion in the electoral roll gives rise to a presumption of validity, it does not impose a blanket prohibition on the powers of the EC to undertake an SIR. The safeguards of notice and hearing under RER are preserved in substance, and the process adopted by the EC is within the statutory requirements. The documentation prescribed by the EC, to which the Aadhaar card was subsequently added as per the court's direction, is based on intelligible criteria having a direct nexus with the objective of ensuring the integrity of the electoral roll. Fourth, the EC is empowered, in the exercise of its constitutional mandate, to undertake a limited enquiry into citizenship for eligibility for inclusion in the electoral roll. It does not amount to a determination of citizenship in the strict sense and is confined to electoral consequences alone.

Any deletion of names on account of the opinion of the EC that they are not citizens should be referred by the commission to the competent authority under the Citizenship Act, 1955, for adjudication of their citizenship. If the authority holds that such deleted individuals are citizens, they shall be included in the electoral roll. (*Rangarajan R is a former IAS officer and author of "Courseware on Polity Simplified". Views expressed are personal.*)

BIBLIOGRAPHY



GETTY IMAGES



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

We talk about a “gaggle of geese”, “a litter of puppies”, and a “school of dolphins”. What do you call a group of peacocks? (A. Ananthan, Chennai) The collective noun that is used with peacocks is “muster”. We talk about a “muster of peacocks”. The “u” is pronounced like the “u” in ‘must’, ‘bust’, and “dust”.

Is it correct to say “each and every”? (T. Balachander, Bangalore) It is very common to hear people say, “I would like to thank each and every one of you for coming tonight”. It is not only Indians who use this expression, but native speakers of English also employ it quite frequently. Careful users of the language however frown on this expression; they argue that it is redundant to say “each and every”. They would prefer that you say, “I would like to thank each one of you for coming tonight”, or “I would like to thank every one of you for coming tonight”. The expression “each and every” is however very commonly used by both native and non-native speakers of English.

What is the origin and meaning of the expression “to get someone’s goat”? (G. Sankunthala, Secunderabad) This is an expression used in informal contexts. When someone gets your goat, he/she makes you very annoyed. Here are a few examples.

Shoba got my goat when she accused me of being laid-back.
I don’t know much about Mohan, but Sunita says he gets her goat. The way Ram bosses his parents gets my goat.
The idiom I understand comes from the world of horse racing. Racehorses are supposed to be highly-strung animals; they have a lot of nervous energy and it is a big job trying to keep these animals calm. In the old days, horse trainers used to put a goat in the stalls of these animals in an effort to keep them calm. The two animals used to bond and very often the horse became attached to its companion – the goat. To ensure that a horse did not perform well in an upcoming race, what many rival horse owners used to do was to steal the goat the night before the race. This used to upset the horse very much and as a result it would underperform in the race. So when you say that someone has got your goat, you are comparing yourself to the horse rather than the goat itself.

What is the meaning of “Bingo”? (T. M. U. Geetha Priya, Chennai) Bingo is a game. What we call “Tambola” and “Housei” in India, people in the West refer to as Bingo. When a player finds that his card contains all the numbers that have been called out, he usually shouts “bingo” to indicate that he has won. In everyday context when someone shouts ‘bingo’, what he means to say is that something rather surprising and pleasant has happened. This rather informal expression is also used to indicate that you have done something successfully. Here are a few examples.
I turned the key for the fifth time and bingo, this time the car started.
Hamsa started to play tennis for exercise and bingo she was hooked.
Published in The Hindu on October 17, 2000

When legal doctrine meets absurdity, comedy, and courtroom theatrics

Comic undercurrents, institutional peculiarities, and unforgettable characters lie hidden beneath the solemnity of courts and the legal profession; through judicial excess, courtroom spectacle, ghosts, and AI hallucinations, the stories reveal the human side of the administration of justice

Kartikey Singh

The law and the legal system form the foundation of societal order. Their legitimacy rests upon procedural discipline, fidelity to constitutional and statutory frameworks, and the promise that disputes will be resolved through reason. Courts are designed to embody this seriousness, with their elevated benches, solemn-looking judges, and black robes. Yet beneath this solemnity lies a less acknowledged history of the legal profession, shaped by vanity, wit, eccentricity, bruised egos, theatricality, and episodes of absurdity that reveal how human the administration of justice has always been. It is this hidden world of law, with its comic undercurrents, institutional peculiarities, and unforgettable characters, that Solicitor General of India Tushar Mehta writes about in his two recently released books, *The Lawful and the Awful: Quirky Tales from the World of Law* and *The Bench, the Bar, and the Bizarre: The Unfamiliar, the Curious, and the Extraordinary in Law*. These volumes, which are about foreign courts and legal systems rather than the Indian judiciary, transform humour into a mode of institutional analysis.

The weight of the robe
The Lawful and the Awful opens with a chapter titled ‘Bench without Borders’. Judges, Mr. Mehta writes, are most often found in the courtroom. Like lions in a jungle, they are possessive of their jurisdiction, and when that jurisdiction is challenged, “various defensive behaviours come into play such as unrealistic expansion of authority, loud vocalisations, displays of dominance and,

at times, outright aggression”. Beneath the humour lies a perceptive study of judicial temperament and the behavioural instincts that courts so often conceal beneath procedural complexity. The rest of the book bears it out, case by case. The range in the book is extraordinary. Judge Phantly Roy Bean of Val Verde County, Texas, who dispensed justice from his tavern called the Jersey Lilly Saloon by sitting on a barrel, kept a black bear named Bruno both as a court enforcer and his pet. He selected juries from among his most regular drinking customers. He sits in the same chapter as Lord Chief Justice Jeffreys of the Bloody Assizes, who in 1685 conducted summary trials from inn to inn across England, sentencing hundreds of people to death while, contemporary accounts suggest, allowing his appetite for fine food and drink to influence his venue selection. The centrepiece of *The Lawful and the Awful* is ‘The Court of One: The Inimitable Justice Scalia’, a long, carefully written portrait of the American jurist whose dissents rewrote the possibilities of judicial prose. Mr. Mehta’s footnoting is impeccable. This matters as these are not apocryphal anecdotes but documented legal history, which is what gives the comedy its particular edge. In law as in life, he observes in the preface, truth is generally more ridiculous than invention. His literature endorses this view on almost every page.

Anxieties of the modern courtroom
The Bench, the Bar, and the Bizarre engages with an equally fascinating range of themes. It confronts the present directly: judicial bullying, the judiciary’s uneasy encounter with social media, the

supernatural in courtrooms, and the vertiginous question of Artificial Intelligence in legal practice. Like its companion, the tone remains composed, observant, and frequently funny. ‘The Divinity Virus: Bullies on the Bench’ opens with the account of Judge Talmadge D. Littlejohn of Mississippi’s 1st Chancery District, who required everyone present to stand and recite the ‘Pledge of Allegiance’ before proceedings commenced. The chapter records that in October 2010, when a lawyer appearing in his court declined to participate, he had to face contempt of court. The pages then throw a light on judicial excess - judges unable to restrain their tempers, repeatedly interrupting counsels, humiliating lawyers, weaponising authority through sarcasm and intimidation, and mistaking institutional power for personal infallibility. Mr. Mehta uses these incidents to reveal how quickly judicial authority, when unchecked, can slide into spectacle and outright misuse. ‘Law beyond the Living: Demons, Devils, Ghosts, and God in Court’, which humorously recounts people taking celestial beings to court, is the liveliest and one of the most insightful chapters in both books. Mr. Mehta revisits the case of *Stambovsky v. Ackley*, where a New York court ruled on the principle of ‘buyer beware’. The owner of a house had publicly claimed in magazines like *Reader’s Digest* that the house was haunted. Later, when a buyer complained during a contract dispute, the court said the owner could not suddenly deny the ghosts existed, since she herself had promoted the house as haunted. What begins as an absurd ghost story evolves into a fascinating example of courts adjudicating questions

seemingly beyond the boundaries of law itself. At a time when the Supreme Court has itself raised concerns over the growing use of AI in legal drafting, the chapter ‘Artificially Intelligent, Legally Embarrassed: Hallucinations, Fake Citations, and the Perils of Robo-Research’ is timely. Mr. Mehta observes that technology is only as effective as its users, and the legal profession, like any other profession, has its share of both those who work hard and those who work hardly. **Miscellany-at-Law series** Those who find themselves drawn deeper into this tradition of legal humour as a mode of serious inquiry would do well to turn next to the classic three-volume *Miscellany-at-Law* series by Sir Robert Megarry, an eminent British lawyer, judge, and legal author, who eventually rose to serve as the Vice-Chancellor of the Supreme Court of England and Wales. Each volume is organised into chapters of themed material – judicial temperament, advocacy, absurd statutes and linguistic oddities of legal drafting. Much like Mr. Mehta’s excavations, the range of the *Miscellanies* is astonishing: a court in Charleston genuinely considering whether horses should be required to wear diapers and a court declining to classify trespassing bees as ‘invitees’, ‘licensees’, or ‘trespassers’. All these stories are documented, footnoted, and placed within their proper legal context so that the comedy, rather than displacing the doctrine, actually sharpens it. (Kartikey Singh, lawyer, and currently working as a Law Clerk-cum-Research Associate at the Supreme Court of India)

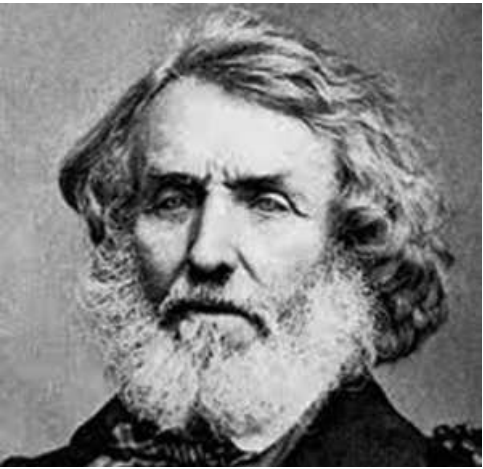
THE DAILY QUIZ

This was the day that Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay became the first people to scale Mount Everest in 1953. A quiz on the tallest peak in the world:

Radhika Santhanam

QUESTION 1
Tibetans and Sherpas call Mt Everest Chomolungma. What does that mean?
QUESTION 2
This is a perilous area on Mt Everest where most mountaineers struggle to carry on because the air contains only about one-third of the oxygen available at sea level. What is it called?
QUESTION 3
Before the Great Trigonometrical Survey of India, which peak was

considered the highest peak in the world? Also, which State government bans mountaineering expeditions from its side on this mountain, which is believed to be sacred?
QUESTION 4
She was the first woman to summit Mt Everest. A mountain range on Pluto is named after her. Name her.
QUESTION 5
Humanity has littered the entire planet, from the peak of Mt Everest to the deepest point on earth. In both places, microplastics have been found. Name the deepest point.



Visual Question:
This man served as Surveyor General of India. He never saw the Everest but he is associated with it. Name him.

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. Now powering most EVs (particularly Chinese ones), LFP batteries owe much of their commercial viability to the polyanion cathode framework pioneered in the late 1980s by Nobel laureate John B. Goodenough and his associate, who was born in a small village in Tamil Nadu. **Ans: Prof. Arumugam Manthiram** 2. From one Goodenough associate to another: while the scientist in Q1 laid the conceptual groundwork, the actual 1997 paper announcing LiFePO₄ as a cathode was led by a scientist from Kalahandi, Odisha. Name him. **Ans: Akshaya Padhi** 3. Named after a Russian mineralogist and first found in the Urals in 1839, identify this crystal structure revolutionising photovoltaics. **Ans: Perovskite** 4. In 1987, a water-well worker in Bourakébougou, Mali, accidentally set off a blue flame that burned for weeks in a borewell. Decades later, the gas was found to be 98% pure. Name this naturally mined, newest “colour” of hydrogen. **Ans: Gold or White or natural Hydrogen** 5. Name the Fujian-born physicist who founded CATL in 2011, the world’s largest battery maker and LFP producer. **Ans: Robin Zeng or Zeng Yuqun** Visual: Name this Victorian mansion in Northumberland, the world’s first home lit by hydroelectricity in 1878, and its industrialist owner. **Ans: Cragside House. William Armstrong** **Early Birds:** Utsav Kaushal | Arun Kumar Singh | Neil Lall | Bhavya Pandey | ViswanadhaRao Batchu

Please send in your answers to
dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Word of the day

Galumph:
move around heavily and clumsily

Synonyms: stomp, stumble, trudge

Usage: She galumphed into the room carrying too many bags.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/galumph

International Phonetic Alphabet: /gəˈlʌmf/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Text & Context’